BEHIND THE CURTAIN

Small-group kit

Eleven sessions for home groups and small groups – one to three chapters each, 75 to 90 minutes each.

SESSION 1	The King among the Lampstands	Revelation 1:1–20
SESSION 10	Come Out of Her	Revelation 17:1 – 19:21
SESSION 11	Come, Lord Jesus	Revelation 20:1 – 22:21
SESSION 2	Four Churches, One Lord	Revelation 2:1–29
SESSION 3	Wake Up, Hold Fast, Open the Door	Revelation 3:1–22
SESSION 4	Who Is Worthy?	Revelation 4:1 – 5:14
SESSION 5	Who Can Stand?	Revelation 6:1 – 7:17
SESSION 6	Heaven Is Listening	Revelation 8:1 – 9:21
SESSION 7	Sweet and Bitter	Revelation 10:1 – 11:19
SESSION 8	Whose Are You?	Revelation 12:1 – 13:18
SESSION 9	The Song on the Shore	Revelation 14:1 – 16:21

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SESSION 1 · REVELATION 1:1–20

The King among the Lampstands

THE BIG IDEA

Revelation pulls back the curtain for small, pressured churches: the one who loves us and has freed us by his blood is the ruler of the kings of the earth, he walks among his churches, holds them in his right hand and says to them – and to us – "Do not be afraid."

TO GET STARTED

Have you ever been allowed behind the scenes somewhere – in a theatre, a restaurant kitchen, a hospital, a stadium? How did it change the way you saw the front stage afterwards?

TIMING

- **10 min** Welcome & opener
- **10 min** Read the passage
- **10 min** Background & original language
- **40 min** Discussion
- **15 min** Application & prayer

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 1:1–20

Read with three voices: a narrator for John's words, a second reader for the song of praise and verse 7 (vv. 5b–7), and a third reader for the words of the Lord (vv. 8, 11 and 17b–20). Verse 3 blesses the one who reads aloud – so read slowly, as the first churches heard it.

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

Revelation was written, probably around AD 95, to seven real churches in the Roman province of Asia (today's western Turkey), where honouring the emperor as lord was part of everyday life and refusing could cost Christians their work, their freedom or their lives. John writes from exile on the island of Patmos. The book's first word, apokalypsis, means unveiling: God pulls back the curtain so that his people can see who really reigns – and what it meant for those seven churches, it means for the church in every age. Tonight we read chapter 1: the greeting and a burst of praise (vv. 1–8), and John's vision of the risen Christ among the lampstands (vv. 9–20).

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

- ***apokalypsis* – ἀποκάλυψις** "revelation": Not chaos and the end of the world, but the removing of a veil – an unveiling. The book was not written to hide God's plans behind codes, but to show believers who really sits on the throne. And it is the revelation of Jesus Christ: he is both its Giver and its Content (1:1).
- ***synkoinōnos* – συγκοινωνός** "who shares with you": John does not stand above the churches as an exalted apostle; he is their brother, a partner who has a share together with them. And what he shares with them are three things that belong together: affliction, the kingdom and endurance (1:9).
- ***lychniai* – λυχνίαι** "lampstands": Not the one seven-branched lampstand of the tabernacle (Exodus 25:31–37; cf. Zechariah 4:2), but seven separate golden lampstands – the seven churches (1:20). A lampstand has no light of its own; it holds up the light. And Christ stands in the middle of them (1:13).

DISCUSSION

1. Verse 3 blesses "the one who reads aloud" and those who hear and keep what is written. Revelation was meant to be read aloud in church and lived, not first of all decoded. What difference does it make to come to this book as a letter to be heard and kept rather than a puzzle to be solved? (Revelation 1:1–3)
2. Before John writes one word about affliction, he bursts into praise: "To him who loves us and has freed us from our sins by his blood". "Loves" is present, "has freed" is past. Why might the churches need to

hear this first? And which of the two do you find harder to believe about yourself? (Revelation 1:4–6)

3. Verse 7 weaves together two Old Testament prophecies: Daniel 7:13 (one like a son of man coming with the clouds of heaven) and Zechariah 12:10 (they will look on the one they have pierced and mourn). Look them up. What did these promises mean in their own setting – and what does John see coming true in Jesus? (Revelation 1:7)
4. The emperor Domitian liked to be called "lord and god". In verse 8 the churches hear: "the Lord God, who is and who was and who is coming, the Almighty". What would that have meant in a city full of temples for the emperor? Which "little emperors" claim that place in our lives today? (Revelation 1:8)
5. John calls himself "your brother, who shares with you in the affliction and the kingdom and the endurance in Jesus". Why do these three belong together? What happens to our faith if we want the kingdom without the affliction and the endurance? (Revelation 1:9)
6. The portrait in verses 13–16 is painted with Old Testament colours (Daniel 7:9; 10:5–6). What does it mean that features of the Ancient of Days – hair white like wool – are given to one like a son of man? Which detail speaks most to you: the eyes like a flame of fire, the voice like many waters, the sword from his mouth? (Revelation 1:12–16)
7. Christ stands "in the middle of the lampstands", and the hand that holds the stars rests on a trembling John: "Do not be afraid. I am the First and the Last". Which fear in your life needs to hear today that he holds "the keys of death and of Hades"? (Revelation 1:17–20)

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- Each morning this week, before you look at the news or your phone, read 1:5–6 aloud and say it in your own words: he loves me – today; he has freed me – it is done.
- Like John on Patmos, praise God in the middle of something hard, not only after it is over: name one difficult situation this week and thank Christ, in so many words, that he holds the keys and walks among his people.

PRAY TOGETHER

Read verses 17–18 aloud together, slowly. Then let each person name (aloud or silently) one fear and hand it over to the one who holds the keys of death and of Hades. Close by praying the doxology of verses 5–6 together as your own praise.

NOTES FOR THE LEADER

- This session covers two devotionals (days 1–2) and opens the series of eleven sessions. Set the lens at the start: Revelation was written to seven churches; what it meant for them, it means for us. Its question is not “when?” but “who really reigns, and whose side am I on?”.
- Some in the group may have learned to read Revelation mainly as a timetable of end-time events still to come (futurist and dispensational readings), others as something fulfilled in the first century (preterist readings). Name this fairly and without polemics, and say that this series reads the book as a message for the church in every age; keep the focus on its pastoral heart: God reigns, the Lamb has conquered, the church is called to faithful witness and endurance.
- “What must soon take place” and “the time is near” (1:1, 3): the devotional notes that John takes up Daniel 2:28, but replaces “in the last days” with “soon” – what was far off for Daniel has begun with Christ, and the whole time between his first and second coming is the last days. Don't let the group calculate dates.
- The “angels” of the seven churches (1:20) are understood in different ways – heavenly angels, or the leaders or messengers of the churches. Mention it briefly and move on. In 1:5 some older Bibles read “washed”; the oldest manuscripts read “freed”.
- Handle with care: some people carry real fear from end-times films, charts or sermons. The first word the risen Christ speaks to the trembling John is “Do not be afraid.” Let that set the tone of the evening.
- Point ahead: next week we read chapter 2 – Ephesus, Smyrna, Pergamum and Thyatira. Ask four people to take one church each, read its letter at home with the devotional of that day, and report briefly next time.

Related devotionals: Day 1 – The Alpha and the Omega – Who Is at the Helm of Your Life? · Day 2 – The Glorified King among the Lampstands

Revelation 1:1–20

1 The revelation of Jesus Christ, which God gave
him to show his servants what must soon take
place. He made it known by sending it through
his angel to his servant John, 2 who testified to
the word of God and to the testimony of Jesus
Christ – everything he saw. 3 Blessed is the one
who reads aloud, and blessed are those who
hear the words of the prophecy and keep what
is written in it, for the time is near.

4 John, to the seven churches in the province of
Asia: Grace to you and peace from him who is
and who was and who is coming, and from the
seven spirits who are before his throne, 5 and
from Jesus Christ, the faithful witness, the
firstborn of the dead and the ruler of the kings
of the earth.

To him who loves us and has freed us from our
sins by his blood
6 – and he made us a kingdom, priests to his God
and Father –
to him be the glory and the might for ever and
ever. Amen.
7 Look, he is coming with the clouds,
and every eye will see him,
even those who pierced him,
and all the tribes of the earth will mourn over
him.
Yes, amen.

8 "I am the Alpha and the Omega," says the Lord
God, who is and who was and who is coming,
the Almighty.

9 I, John, your brother, who shares with you in
the affliction and the kingdom and the en-
durance in Jesus, was on the island called
Patmos because of the word of God and the tes-
timony of Jesus. 10 On the Lord's day I came to
be in the Spirit, and behind me I heard a loud
voice like a trumpet, 11 saying, "Write what you
see in a book and send it to the seven churches:
to Ephesus, to Smyrna, to Pergamum, to
Thyatira, to Sardis, to Philadelphia and to
Laodicea." 12 And I turned to see the voice that
was speaking with me. And when I had turned,
I saw seven golden lampstands, 13 and in the
middle of the lampstands one like a son of man,
dressed in a robe that reached to his feet, with a
golden sash around his chest. 14 His head and
his hair were white like white wool, like snow,
and his eyes were like a flame of fire; 15 his feet
were like burnished bronze, as if glowing in a
furnace, and his voice was like the sound of
many waters. 16 In his right hand he had seven
stars, out of his mouth came a sharp two-edged
sword, and his face was like the sun shining in
its power.

17 When I saw him, I fell at his feet as though
dead. And he placed his right hand on me and
said, "Do not be afraid. I am the First and the
Last, 18 and the Living One. I was dead, and
look, I am alive for ever and ever, and I have the
keys of death and of Hades. 19 So write down
what you have seen, what is, and what is going
to take place after this. 20 As for the mystery of
the seven stars that you saw in my right hand,
and the seven golden lampstands: the seven
stars are the angels of the seven churches, and
the seven lampstands are the seven churches."

SESSION 10 · REVELATION 17:1 – 19:21

Come Out of Her

THE BIG IDEA

Babylon – the seductive power of every age that rides on the beast, lives in luxury, trades in bodies and souls and is drunk with the blood of the saints – looks impressive but falls in a single hour; God calls his people to come out of her, not out of the world, and invites them to the wedding of the Lamb, whose Rider, Faithful and True, conquers by the word of his mouth.

TO GET STARTED

Think of an advertisement, a product or a lifestyle that once really impressed you. What made it so attractive – and did it keep its promise?

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 17:1 – 19:21

The chapters are long: read 17:1–6 and 17:14–18, all of chapter 18 and all of chapter 19. In chapter 18 let three readers take the laments of the kings (vv. 9–10), the merchants (vv. 11–17a) and the sailors (vv. 17b–19); the whole group reads the Hallelujahs of 19:1–8 together.

TIMING

5 min	Welcome & opener
15 min	Read the passage
10 min	Background & original language
45 min	Discussion
15 min	Application & prayer

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

At the last bowl the voice from the throne cried "It is done!", and God "remembered Babylon the Great" (16:19). Chapters 17–19 show who she is. For the seven churches she was Rome on her seven hills, rich, glamorous and violent; in the Bible's great story she is every power since Babel that seduces people with luxury and makes them forget to whom they belong. Chapter 18 is the lament over her fall and the call to God's people to come out; chapter 19 answers with heaven's Hallelujah, the wedding of the Lamb and the Rider on the white horse – Christ's return, which still lies ahead of us.

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

- ***Exelthate, ho laos mou, ex autēs* – Ἐξέλθατε, ὁ λαός μου, ἐξ αὐτῆς** "Come out of her, my people": Jeremiah's call to the exiles in ancient Babylon (Jeremiah 51:6, 45). The Greek Old Testament uses the same verb for Israel's exodus from Egypt (Exodus 13:3). It is a new exodus – out of Babylon, not out of creation; the goal is the city where God dwells with people (21:1–3).
- ***sōmatōn, kai psychas anthrōpōn* – σωμάτων, καὶ ψυχὰς ἀνθρώπων** "bodies – and human souls": The last items on Babylon's cargo list. "Bodies" was a trade word for slaves; here the Greek suddenly changes its construction, as though John interrupts the list to say what the merchants did not want to see: these are souls. The Lamb purchased people for God (5:9); Babylon buys and sells them.
- ***pistos … kai alēthinos* – πιστὸς … καὶ ἀληθινός** "Faithful and True": Pistos is someone who keeps his word; alēthinos is the genuine thing as against the counterfeit. In a book full of counterfeits – a beast that looks as though slain (13:3), a false prophet with horns like a lamb (13:11) – the Rider is the Genuine One. It is how Jesus introduced himself to Laodicea (3:14).

DISCUSSION

1. John hears of "the great prostitute who sits on many waters", then sees "a woman sitting on a scarlet beast". How does the seeing interpret the hearing? What would the churches have recognised when

the angel speaks of seven mountains and of "the great city that has a kingdom over the kings of the earth"? (Revelation 17:1–18)

2. "And when I saw her, I was greatly amazed." The angel asks: "Why are you amazed?" Babylon appears not as a monster but as a queen in purple with a golden cup. What impresses you so much at the moment that it begins to draw your heart away from the Lamb? Behind the glamour, what is it riding on – and who pays for it? (Revelation 17:3–7)
3. The Old Testament in the New: read Jeremiah 51:6–8 and Isaiah 47:7–8 aloud and compare them with 18:2–8. What does it tell us that the voice from heaven uses Jeremiah's words, "Come out of her, my people"? What kind of exodus is this – out of the world, or out of something else? What would it mean for your work and your spending? (Revelation 18:2–8)
4. In her heart Babylon says: "I sit as a queen; I am no widow, and I will never see grief." Laodicea said: "I am rich, I have become wealthy, and I need nothing" (3:17). Where do you hear that voice in your own heart – "if I have enough, nothing can touch me"? (Revelation 18:7)
5. The merchants do not weep over the city or over the slaves, but "because no one buys their cargo any more" – and the list ends with "bodies – and human souls". What does our grief show about what our hearts are bound to? Who might be only "cargo" to us – people whose work we use without really seeing them? (Revelation 18:11–24)
6. Hallelujah, "for the wedding of the Lamb has come, and his wife has made herself ready." The prostitute bought her purple and gold; the bride is given fine linen, shining and clean. Do you see the church more as a failure or as the bride of the Lamb? And do you try to earn your robe, or receive it as a gift? (Revelation 19:1–10)
7. The Rider is "called Faithful and True"; his robe is dipped in blood before any fight, and no battle is described – only the sword from his mouth. Which of God's promises do you find hard to believe at the moment? And when did you last fight with the beast's weapons – anger, manipulation, power – instead of the word? (Revelation 19:11–21)

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- Choose one act of "coming out" this week: give away something you would like to keep, or, with one purchase, ask who the people behind it are and pray for them – not out of guilt, but as someone who already belongs to the Lamb.
- Choose one conversation in which you are tempted to win with harsh words. Pray Hebrews 4:12 beforehand, and then speak one true word in love instead of the word that wounds.

PRAY TOGETHER

Read 19:6–8 aloud together. Then pray in pairs: name before God one thing that amazes you more than the Lamb; pray for people who are treated as cargo – exploited workers, trafficked people, those whose worth is measured by what they produce; and thank the Rider, Faithful and True, for one promise he has kept. Close together: "Hallelujah! For the Lord God, the Almighty has begun to reign."

NOTES FOR THE LEADER

- This is the fullest session: three long chapters and four devotionals (days 23–26). Follow the reading tip and choose five questions; 2, 4 and 6 are the heart of the evening.
- Who is Babylon? For the first readers clearly Rome (the seven mountains, 17:9; the great city, 17:18), but in the Bible's story she is every power since Babel (Genesis 11:4) that seduces with luxury, violence and idolatry. Do not decode the seven kings (17:9–11) into a list of emperors, or the beast into a modern state, institution or church. Futurist readers expect an end-time Babylon or world system, preterist readers see only Rome; name both fairly in a sentence and return to the book's question: whose am I?
- Handle “in or out” with care. Two women and two cities are a call to faithfulness, not a tool for labelling other people as Babylon. Nor is chapter 18 a sermon against money or trade – wheat, wine and olive oil are good gifts of God. The issue is the heart that says “I will never see grief”, and the people behind the goods.
- The text calls Babylon a “prostitute” and speaks of “harlotry”. In the prophets this is the picture of unfaithfulness to God – giving your love and trust to other powers (Hosea 2; Ezekiel 16; Nahum 3:4). If someone is uneasy with the image, explain it briefly: it is about where we give our hearts.
- 19:11–21 is Christ's return, which still lies ahead. The terrible supper of 19:17–18 takes up Ezekiel 39:17–20: evil is utterly and finally defeated. Point to the two suppers – everyone is first invited to the wedding supper of the Lamb (19:9). And 19:10 is a good moment to ask what we are tempted to worship in God's place: “Worship God!”
- Point ahead: next week is the last session, chapters 20–22 – the dragon on a chain, all things made new, the bride who is a city, the river and the tree of life, and “Come, Lord Jesus”.

Related devotionals: Day 23 – The Prostitute on the Beast: Why Are You Amazed? · Day 24 – Come Out of Her, My People: The Fall of Babylon · Day 25 – The Wedding of the Lamb: A Robe That Is Given · Day 26 – Faithful and True: The Rider on the White Horse

Revelation 17:1 – 19:21

1 And one of the seven angels who had the seven
bowls came and spoke with me, saying, "Come,
I will show you the judgement of the great pros-
titute who sits on many waters, 2 with whom
the kings of the earth committed harlotry, and
those who live on the earth became drunk with
the wine of her harlotry." 3 And he carried me
away in the Spirit into a wilderness. And I saw a
woman sitting on a scarlet beast that was full of
names of blasphemy and had seven heads and
ten horns. 4 And the woman was dressed in pur-
ple and scarlet and adorned with gold and pre-
cious stone and pearls; she had in her hand a
golden cup full of abominations and the impu-
rities of her harlotry, 5 and on her forehead a
name was written, a mystery: "Babylon the
Great, the mother of prostitutes and of the
abominations of the earth." 6 And I saw the
woman drunk with the blood of the saints and
with the blood of the witnesses to Jesus. And
when I saw her, I was greatly amazed.

7 And the angel said to me, "Why are you
amazed? I will tell you the mystery of the
woman and of the beast that carries her, which
has the seven heads and the ten horns. 8 The
beast that you saw was, and is not, and is about
to come up out of the abyss and go to destruc-
tion. And those who live on the earth, whose
name has not been written in the book of life
from the foundation of the world, will be
amazed when they see the beast, because it was
and is not and will be present. 9 Here is the un-
derstanding that has wisdom: the seven heads
are seven mountains on which the woman sits.
They are also seven kings: 10 five have fallen, one
is, the other has not yet come; and when he
comes, he must remain only a little while.
11 And the beast that was and is not is itself an
eighth, and it belongs to the seven, and it goes
to destruction. 12 And the ten horns that you
saw are ten kings who have not yet received a
kingdom, but they receive authority as kings
for one hour together with the beast. 13 These
have one purpose, and they give their power
and authority to the beast. 14 These will make
war on the Lamb, and the Lamb will conquer
them, for he is Lord of lords and King of kings,
and those with him are called and chosen and
faithful." 15 And he says to me, "The waters that
you saw, where the prostitute sits, are peoples
and crowds and nations and languages. 16 And
the ten horns that you saw, and the beast, these
will hate the prostitute; they will make her dev-
astated and naked, and they will eat her flesh
and burn her up with fire. 17 For God has put it
into their hearts to carry out his purpose, to
carry out one purpose, and to give their king-
dom to the beast, until the words of God are ful-
filled. 18 And the woman that you saw is the
great city that has a kingdom over the kings of
the earth."

1 After this I saw another angel coming down
from heaven, who had great authority, and the
earth was lit up by his glory. 2 And he cried out
with a mighty voice, saying:

Fallen, fallen is Babylon the Great!
She has become a dwelling place of demons,
a prison of every unclean spirit,
a prison of every unclean bird,
a prison of every unclean and hated beast.
3 For by the wine of the fury of her harlotry
all the nations have fallen,
and the kings of the earth committed harlotry
with her,
and the merchants of the earth grew rich
from the power of her luxury.

4 And I heard another voice from heaven
saying:

Come out of her, my people,
so that you do not share in her sins
and do not receive any of her plagues.
5 For her sins have piled up to heaven,
and God has remembered her crimes.

6 Repay her as she herself has repaid,
and pay her back double for her works;
in the cup in which she mixed, mix her a double portion.
7 As much as she glorified herself and lived in luxury,
so much torment and grief give her.
For in her heart she says:
I sit as a queen;
I am no widow,
and I will never see grief.
8 That is why her plagues will come in a single day,
pestilence and grief and famine,
and she will be burned up with fire;
for mighty is the Lord God who has judged her.

9 And the kings of the earth who committed harlotry with her and lived in luxury will weep and mourn over her when they see the smoke of her burning. 10 They will stand far off for fear of her torment and say:

Woe, woe, the great city,
Babylon, the mighty city!
For in one hour your judgement has come.

11 And the merchants of the earth weep and grieve over her, because no one buys their cargo any more, 12 cargo of gold and silver and precious stone and pearls, and fine linen and purple and silk and scarlet, and all kinds of citron wood and every article of ivory and every article of most precious wood and bronze and iron and marble, 13 and cinnamon and spice and incense and perfumed oil and frankincense, and wine and olive oil and fine flour and wheat, and cattle and sheep, and horses and carriages, and bodies – and human souls.

14 And the fruit your soul longed for
has gone from you,
and all the luxuries and the splendour
are lost to you,
and they will never find them again.

15 The merchants of these things, who grew rich from her, will stand far off for fear of her torment, weeping and grieving, 16 and say:

Woe, woe, the great city,
dressed in fine linen and purple and scarlet,
and adorned with gold and precious stone and pearl!
17 For in one hour such great wealth has been devastated.
And every ship's captain and everyone who sails anywhere, and sailors and all who make their living from the sea, stood far off

18 and cried out when they saw the smoke of her burning, saying, "Who is like the great city?"
19 And they threw dust on their heads and cried out, weeping and grieving, and said:

Woe, woe, the great city,
in which all who had ships on the sea
grew rich from her costly wealth!
For in one hour she has been devastated.
20 Rejoice over her, heaven,
and you saints and apostles and prophets,
for God has judged your case against her.

21 And a mighty angel picked up a stone like a great millstone and threw it into the sea, saying:

So with violence Babylon, the great city, will be thrown down,
and will never be found again.
22 And the sound of lyre players and musicians,
of flute players and trumpeters,
will never be heard in you again,
and no craftsman of any craft
will ever be found in you again,
and the sound of the mill
will never be heard in you again,
23 and the light of a lamp
will never shine in you again,
and the voice of bridegroom and bride
will never be heard in you again.
For your merchants were the nobles of the earth,
for by your sorcery all the nations were deceived,

[24] and in her was found the blood of prophets
and of saints
and of all who have been slaughtered on the
earth.

[1] After this I heard something like the loud
voice of a great crowd in heaven, saying:

Hallelujah!
The salvation and the glory and the power be-
long to our God,
[2] for true and just are his judgements;
for he has judged the great prostitute
who corrupted the earth with her harlotry,
and he has avenged the blood of his servants
from her hand.

[3] And a second time they said:

Hallelujah!
Her smoke goes up for ever and ever.

[4] And the twenty-four elders and the four living
creatures fell down and worshipped God, who
sits on the throne, saying:

Amen. Hallelujah!

[5] And a voice came out from the throne, saying:

Praise our God, all his servants,
and you who fear him, the small and the great!

[6] And I heard something like the voice of a great
crowd, and like the sound of many waters, and
like the sound of mighty thunder, saying:

Hallelujah!
For the Lord God, the Almighty has begun to
reign.
[7] Let us rejoice and be glad,
and we will give him the glory,
for the wedding of the Lamb has come,
and his wife has made herself ready.
[8] And it was given to her to clothe herself
in fine linen, shining and clean;
for the fine linen is the righteous acts of the
saints.

[9] And he says to me, "Write: Blessed are those
who are invited to the wedding supper of the
Lamb." And he says to me, "These are the true
words of God." [10] And I fell down at his feet to
worship him. And he says to me, "Do not do
that! I am a fellow servant with you and with
your brothers and sisters who hold to the testi-
mony of Jesus. Worship God! For the testimony
of Jesus is the spirit of prophecy."

[11] And I saw heaven opened, and there was a
white horse, and its rider is called Faithful and
True, and in righteousness he judges and makes
war. [12] His eyes are a flame of fire, and on his
head are many diadems, and he has a name
written that no one knows except himself.
[13] And he is dressed in a robe dipped in blood,
and his name is called The Word of God. [14] And
the armies that are in heaven followed him on
white horses, dressed in fine linen, white and
clean. [15] And out of his mouth comes a sharp
sword with which to strike down the nations,
and he will shepherd them with an iron rod;
and he treads the winepress of the wine of the
fury of the wrath of God, the Almighty. [16] And
on his robe and on his thigh he has a name writ-
ten: King of kings and Lord of lords.

[17] And I saw an angel standing in the sun, and he
cried out with a loud voice, saying to all the
birds that fly in midheaven, "Come, gather for
the great supper of God, [18] to eat the flesh of
kings and the flesh of generals and the flesh of
the powerful and the flesh of horses and their
riders, and the flesh of all, free and slave, small
and great." [19] And I saw the beast and the kings
of the earth and their armies gathered to make
war on the rider of the horse and on his army.
[20] And the beast was captured, and with it the
false prophet who had performed the signs be-
fore it, by which he deceived those who had re-
ceived the mark of the beast and those who
worshipped its image. The two of them were
thrown alive into the lake of fire that burns
with sulphur. [21] And the rest were killed with
the sword of the rider of the horse, the sword
that came out of his mouth, and all the birds
gorged themselves on their flesh.

SESSION 11 · REVELATION 20:1 – 22:21

Come, Lord Jesus

THE BIG IDEA

Behind the curtain Christ reigns now and Satan is on a chain, so that he cannot stop the gospel; the story that began in Eden ends not with an escape from the world but with God making all things new and dwelling with his people face to face – and so the church waits, awake and faithful, praying: "Amen. Come, Lord Jesus!"

TO GET STARTED

What is the best homecoming you can remember – after a journey, a stay in hospital or a long time away? What made it feel like home?

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 20:1 – 22:21

Five readers: 20:1–10; 20:11–21:8; 21:9–27; 22:1–9; 22:10–21. The whole group reads the hymn of 21:3–4 together, and at the very end everyone says 22:20–21 aloud.

TIMING

5 min	Welcome & opener
15 min	Read the passage
10 min	Background & original language
40 min	Discussion
20 min	Application & prayer

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

Chapter 19 showed Christ's return. Chapter 20 steps back once more and shows the time we live in from another angle: the dragon bound for a thousand years while Christ reigns with his people, then the last short revolt and the great white throne. Chapters 21–22 show what remains when everything evil is gone: a new heaven and a new earth, the bride who is a city, the river and the tree of life from Eden, and the face of God. And the book ends as it began – as a letter to the seven churches, with the promise "I am coming soon" and with grace.

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

- ***edēsen* – ἔδησεν** "bound": From deō, "bind" – the same verb Jesus uses for binding the strong man before plundering his house (Mark 3:27). The binding of Satan begins at the cross (John 12:31–32): he can still do harm, but he can no longer stop the gospel among the nations (20:3).
- ***Idou kaina poiō panta* – Ἰδοὺ καινὰ ποιῶ πάντα** "Look, I am making all things new": One of the few places where the one seated on the throne speaks himself (cf. 1:8). He does not throw his creation away; he makes all things new. And the verb is in the present tense: whoever is in Christ is already a new creation (2 Corinthians 5:17).
- ***erchou, kyrie Iēsou* – ἔρχου, κύριε Ἰησοῦ** "Come, Lord Jesus": The early church probably prayed the same prayer in Aramaic, Marana tha – "Our Lord, come!" (1 Corinthians 16:22); according to the Didache (10:6) it belonged to the prayers at the Lord's Supper. It is the answer to his promise, "I am coming soon" (22:20).

DISCUSSION

1. An angel binds the dragon "so that he would deceive the nations no more" (compare Mark 3:27). If the thousand years are the time we live in now, between Christ's first and second coming, where do you see that the chain holds – that Satan cannot stop the gospel? And where does it not feel like that at all?
   (Revelation 20:1–3)
2. Those "beheaded because of the testimony of Jesus" lived and reigned with Christ for a thousand years. To the world they had lost; behind the curtain they reign. What would this have meant for a church

that remembered Antipas (2:13)? How does it comfort you about loved ones who have died in faith? (Revelation 20:4–6)

3. Before the great white throne "books were opened. And another book was opened, which is the book of life." We are judged according to our works, but the last word comes from the book of life of the Lamb (21:27; Luke 10:20). How does this hold together the seriousness of our lives and the assurance of grace? (Revelation 20:11–15)

4. Read Genesis 2:8–10 and 3:17–24, then Revelation 22:1–5. What was lost in Eden, and what comes back? What is greater than at the beginning – a garden that has become a city, the tree of life in the middle of its street, no more curse, and "they will see his face"? (If there is time, compare Ezekiel 47:1–12.) (Revelation 22:1–5)

5. "Look, God's tent is with people" – tabernacle language (Exodus 25:8; John 1:14). We do not escape to a distant heaven; God comes to dwell with us, and "he will wipe away every tear from their eyes". Which tear are you still carrying? What does it mean that he says "Look, I am making all things new" in the present tense? (Revelation 21:1–7)

6. The angel who showed John the prostitute (17:1) now shows him "the bride, the wife of the Lamb": a city with no temple, because God and the Lamb are its temple. What does that mean for your Monday? And for your congregation, with all its quirks, that the bride is a people, not a collection of individuals? (Revelation 21:9–27)

7. Three times we hear "I am coming soon", and between the warnings stands the invitation: "And the Spirit and the bride say, 'Come!'" How does Jesus' "soon" shape the way we wait – not with dates, but with readiness? Whom could you invite this week to come and drink the water of life as a gift? (Revelation 22:6–21)

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- Every morning this week, pray the last prayer of the Bible: "Amen. Come, Lord Jesus!" Add the name of one person you would like to invite to come and drink the water of life (22:17).
- Write down one tear you are still carrying and read 21:3–5 aloud beside it. Then say to God: This one too you will wipe away. And pray once this week for a people or country where the gospel is still little known.

PRAY TOGETHER

This evening closes the series. Begin with a round of thanks: each person says in one sentence what they have seen behind the curtain in Revelation that they want to keep. Then pray for the persecuted church, for one people where the gospel is still little known, and for one another. End by standing and reading 22:20–21 aloud together: "Amen. Come, Lord Jesus! The grace of the Lord Jesus be with all."

NOTES FOR THE LEADER

- Last session: three chapters and five devotionals (days 27–31). Choose five of the seven questions and keep at least 20 minutes for looking back and for the closing prayer.
- The thousand years (20:1–6): this series follows the reading known in the church since Augustine – the time between Christ's first and second coming, in which Christ reigns and his people with him, and Satan is bound so that he cannot stop the gospel among the nations. Premillennialists (already Justin and Irenaeus, later the dispensationalists) expect a literal thousand-year kingdom on earth after Christ's return; postmillennialists expect a golden age of the gospel before it. Name these views fairly and do not let the evening become a debate: all agree that Christ will return, judge and make all things new.
- Chapter 20 does not necessarily follow chapter 19 in time. The same final war ("the war", 16:14; 19:19; 20:8) is seen from different angles, and each time there is no real fight: the end comes from the throne.
- Handle the great white throne and the lake of fire (20:11–15; 21:8) with care: some people will feel fear, others grief for loved ones. Do not speculate about who is in the book of life; point to the Lamb who holds it. "The cowardly" (21:8) are not people who are afraid and weak, but those who out of fear gave up Christ – and the door still stands open: whoever is thirsty may come (21:6; 22:17).
- The measurements of the city (twelve thousand stadia, a hundred and forty-four cubits) are numbers for wonder, not for maps: twelve is the people of God, and the cube recalls the Most Holy Place (1 Kings 6:20). Interpreters differ on whether the new creation is wholly new or the old renewed; the point is the same – God does not give up his creation.
- "Soon" (22:7, 12, 20) is not a date but a promise that keeps every generation awake (2 Peter 3:8–9; Habakkuk 2:3). Avoid date-setting and fear. If your church's practice allows, the series can close with the Lord's Supper as a foretaste of the wedding supper of the Lamb (19:9).

Related devotionals: Day 27 – The Dragon on a Chain: The Thousand Years and the Book of Life · Day 28 – Look, I Am Making All Things New: A New Heaven and a New Earth · Day 29 – The Bride Is a City: Where God Himself Is the Temple · Day 30 – The River and the Tree of Life: The Garden Open Again · Day 31 – Come, Lord Jesus: The Curtain Stays Open

Revelation 20:1 – 22:21

1 And I saw an angel coming down from heaven,
holding in his hand the key of the abyss and a
great chain. 2 And he seized the dragon, the an-
cient serpent, who is the devil and Satan, and
bound him for a thousand years, 3 and threw
him into the abyss and locked it and sealed it
over him, so that he would deceive the nations
no more until the thousand years were com-
pleted. After that he must be released for a
short time.

4 And I saw thrones, and they sat on them, and
judgement was given to them. And I saw the
souls of those who had been beheaded because
of the testimony of Jesus and because of the
word of God, and who had not worshipped the
beast or its image and had not received the
mark on their foreheads or on their hands. And
they lived and reigned with Christ for a thou-
sand years. 5 The rest of the dead did not live un-
til the thousand years were completed. This is
the first resurrection. 6 Blessed and holy is the
one who has a share in the first resurrection.
Over these the second death has no authority,
but they will be priests of God and of Christ,
and they will reign with him for a thousand
years.

7 And when the thousand years are completed,
Satan will be released from his prison 8 and will
go out to deceive the nations at the four corners
of the earth, Gog and Magog, to gather them for
the war; their number is like the sand of the
sea. 9 And they went up across the breadth of
the earth and surrounded the camp of the
saints and the beloved city. And fire came down
from heaven and consumed them. 10 And the
devil, who deceived them, was thrown into the
lake of fire and sulphur, where the beast and
the false prophet are as well, and they will be
tormented day and night for ever and ever.

11 And I saw a great white throne and the one
seated on it. Earth and heaven fled from his
face, and no place was found for them. 12 And I
saw the dead, the great and the small, standing
before the throne, and books were opened. And
another book was opened, which is the book of
life. And the dead were judged by what was
written in the books, according to their works.
13 And the sea gave up the dead who were in it,
and death and Hades gave up the dead who
were in them, and they were judged, each one
according to their works. 14 And death and
Hades were thrown into the lake of fire. This is
the second death, the lake of fire. 15 And if any-
one was not found written in the book of life,
he was thrown into the lake of fire.

1 And I saw a new heaven and a new earth; for
the first heaven and the first earth had passed
away, and the sea is no more. 2 And I saw the
holy city, the new Jerusalem, coming down out
of heaven from God, prepared like a bride
adorned for her husband. 3 And I heard a loud
voice from the throne saying:

Look, God's tent is with people,
and he will spread his tent with them,
and they will be his peoples,
and God himself will be with them,
4 and he will wipe away every tear from their
eyes,
and death will be no more,
nor grief nor crying nor pain will be any more.
The former things have passed away.

5 And the one seated on the throne said, "Look, I
am making all things new." And he says, "Write,
for these words are faithful and true." 6 And he
said to me, "It is done! I am the Alpha and the
Omega, the beginning and the end. To the
thirsty I will give from the spring of the water
of life as a gift. 7 The one who conquers will in-
herit these things, and I will be his God, and he
will be my son. 8 But for the cowardly and the
faithless and the abominable and murderers
and the sexually immoral and sorcerers and

idolaters and all liars, their share will be in the lake that burns with fire and sulphur, which is the second death."

9 And one of the seven angels who had the seven bowls full of the seven last plagues came and spoke with me, saying, "Come, I will show you the bride, the wife of the Lamb." 10 And he carried me away in the Spirit to a great, high mountain and showed me the holy city Jerusalem coming down out of heaven from God, 11 having the glory of God. Its radiance was like a most precious stone, like a jasper, clear as crystal. 12 It had a great, high wall with twelve gates, and at the gates twelve angels, and names written on them, which are the names of the twelve tribes of the people of Israel: 13 on the east three gates, and on the north three gates, and on the south three gates, and on the west three gates. 14 And the wall of the city had twelve foundations, and on them the twelve names of the twelve apostles of the Lamb.

15 And the one who spoke with me had a gold measuring reed to measure the city and its gates and its wall. 16 And the city lies foursquare; its length is as great as its width. And he measured the city with the reed: twelve thousand stadia. Its length and width and height are equal. 17 And he measured its wall: a hundred and forty-four cubits, by human measure, which is also an angel's measure. 18 And the wall was built of jasper, and the city was pure gold, like clear glass. 19 The foundations of the wall of the city were adorned with every kind of precious stone: the first foundation was jasper, the second sapphire, the third chalcedony, the fourth emerald, 20 the fifth sardonyx, the sixth carnelian, the seventh chrysolite, the eighth beryl, the ninth topaz, the tenth chrysoprase, the eleventh jacinth, the twelfth amethyst. 21 And the twelve gates were twelve pearls; each of the gates was made of a single pearl. And the street of the city was pure gold, like transparent glass.

22 And I saw no temple in it, for its temple is the Lord God, the Almighty, and the Lamb. 23 And the city has no need of the sun or of the moon to shine on it, for the glory of God has given it light, and its lamp is the Lamb. 24 And the nations will walk by its light, and the kings of the earth bring their glory into it. 25 And its gates will never be shut by day, for there will be no night there. 26 And they will bring the glory and the honour of the nations into it. 27 But nothing unclean will ever enter it, nor anyone who practises abomination and lies, but only those who are written in the book of life of the Lamb.

1 And he showed me a river of the water of life, bright as crystal, flowing out from the throne of God and of the Lamb 2 through the middle of the city's street. And on either side of the river was the tree of life, bearing twelve kinds of fruit, yielding its fruit each month; and the leaves of the tree are for the healing of the nations. 3 And there will no longer be any curse. And the throne of God and of the Lamb will be in it, and his servants will serve him, 4 and they will see his face, and his name will be on their foreheads. 5 And there will be no more night, and they have no need of the light of a lamp or the light of the sun, for the Lord God will shine on them, and they will reign for ever and ever.

6 And he said to me, "These words are faithful and true. And the Lord, the God of the spirits of the prophets, has sent his angel to show his servants what must soon take place. 7 And look, I am coming soon. Blessed is the one who keeps the words of the prophecy of this book."

8 And I, John, am the one who heard and saw these things. And when I heard and saw them, I fell down to worship at the feet of the angel who showed them to me. 9 And he says to me, "Do not do that! I am a fellow servant with you and with your brothers and sisters the prophets, and with those who keep the words of this book. Worship God!"

10 And he says to me, "Do not seal up the words of the prophecy of this book, for the time is

near. [11] Let the one who does wrong still do
wrong, and the filthy still be filthy, and the
righteous still do what is right, and the holy
still be holy. [12] Look, I am coming soon, and my
reward is with me, to repay each one according
to what he has done. [13] I am the Alpha and the
Omega, the First and the Last, the beginning
and the end. [14] Blessed are those who wash their
robes, so that they may have the right to the
tree of life and may go through the gates into
the city. [15] Outside are the dogs and the sorcer-
ers and the sexually immoral and the murder-
ers and the idolaters, and everyone who loves
and practises lies. [16] I, Jesus, have sent my angel
to testify to you about these things for the
churches. I am the root and the descendant of
David, the bright morning star."

[17] And the Spirit and the bride say, "Come!" And
let the one who hears say, "Come!" And let the
one who is thirsty come; let the one who wishes
take the water of life as a gift.

[18] I testify to everyone who hears the words of
the prophecy of this book: if anyone adds to
them, God will add to him the plagues that are
written in this book. [19] And if anyone takes
away from the words of the book of this
prophecy, God will take away his share in the
tree of life and in the holy city, which are writ-
ten about in this book.

[20] The one who testifies to these things says,
"Yes, I am coming soon." Amen. Come, Lord
Jesus!

[21] The grace of the Lord Jesus be with all.

SESSION 2 · REVELATION 2:1–29

Four Churches, One Lord

THE BIG IDEA

The one who walks among the lampstands knows each church as it really is – Ephesus's loveless orthodoxy, Smyrna's rich poverty, Pergamum's quiet compromise and Thyatira's loving tolerance – and calls each of them, and us, to hear, repent, hold fast and conquer.

TO GET STARTED

Imagine that someone who knows you well writes you a short, honest letter: one thing they admire in you and one thing that worries them. What do you think it would say? (You do not have to share the answer.)

TIMING

10 min	Welcome & opener
15 min	Read the passage
10 min	Background & original language
40 min	Discussion
15 min	Application & prayer

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 2:1–29

Let the four members who each took a church read their letter (vv. 1–7, 8–11, 12–17, 18–29) as if it were addressed to their own congregation. The whole group reads the refrain together each time: "Whoever has an ear should hear what the Spirit says to the churches."

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

The seven cities lie on a circular road, probably the route a messenger from Patmos would follow: first Ephesus, then Smyrna, Pergamum and Thyatira. Each letter follows a pattern – a title of Christ taken from chapter 1, "I know …", praise or rebuke, a call to repent or to hold fast, a promise to the one who conquers, and the call to hear. The letters were not private mail: "what the Spirit says to the churches" was read aloud in all seven, so every church heard every letter – and so do we.

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

- ***aphiēmi* – ἀφίημι** "abandoned": Ephesus had not lost its first love the way you lose your car keys; it had let go of it, left it behind (2:4). The same verb returns in Thyatira: "you tolerate" – literally, you let her go on (2:20). Ephesus let go of love; Thyatira let go of its duty to stop evil.
- ***ptōcheia* – πτωχεία** "poverty": Not the modest poverty of having just enough (penia), but the beggar's poverty of having nothing at all – the price Smyrna's Christians paid for refusing to honour the emperor. And then Christ's four words: "but you are rich" (2:9).
- ***psēphos leukē* – ψῆφος λευκή** "white stone": In a law court a white pebble could mean acquittal; small stones or tablets also served as admission tickets to a banquet. To believers condemned by Rome and shut out of the guild feasts, Christ gives acquittal and a place at his own table – with a new name known only to the one who receives it (2:17).

DISCUSSION

1. Each reporter: with which title does Christ introduce himself in your letter, and why does it fit that city? (Ephesus: the one who walks among the lampstands; Smyrna: the one who was dead and came to life; Pergamum: the sword, in the city of the governor's sword; Thyatira: the Son of God, in the city of a "son of Zeus".) (Revelation 2:1–18)

2. Ephesus: “I know your works, your toil and your endurance” – and yet “you have abandoned your first love”. How can a church, or a Christian, be busy and right and still have left love behind? What were your own “first works” when grace first overwhelmed you? (Revelation 2:2–5)
3. Smyrna: “I know your affliction and your poverty – but you are rich”. The affliction is real, but it lasts “ten days” – intense, yet measured out by God. How does this change the way you look at a hard season, or at your own idea of being blessed? (Revelation 2:8–11)
4. Pergamum: “I know where you live: where the throne of Satan is.” Christ honours Antipas with his own title from 1:5: “my witness, my faithful one”. What does your “Pergamum” look like – the place where you feel pressure to honour another lord or to keep quiet about yours? (Revelation 2:12–13)
5. Two names from the Old Testament: Balaam (read Numbers 25:1–3 and 31:16) and Jezebel (1 Kings 16:31–33; 21:25). What did they do to Israel – not by open attack, but by seduction? Why might Jesus use these names for teachers inside the church, and where do we meet the same kind of reasoning today? (Revelation 2:14–20)
6. Ephesus could not bear evil people but had let go of love; Thyatira overflowed with love, faith, service and endurance – but “you tolerate the woman Jezebel”. Which of the two is the greater danger for you, and for our church? (Revelation 2:19–25)
7. Look at the promises: the tree of life (Genesis 2–3), the crown of life, the hidden manna and the white stone, authority with the Messiah (Psalm 2:8–9) and the morning star (cf. 22:16). Which promise speaks most to you, and why? What would “conquering” look like for you this week? (Revelation 2:7–28)

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- Read “your” church's letter once more each day this week and write down one sentence: what would the risen Christ say to me in this letter?
- Name one small compromise – one “pinch of incense” – that you have been calling “not that bad”, and take one concrete step away from it; or take up again one “first work” of simple love for Jesus.

PRAY TOGETHER

Pray for the four churches in turn: for first love (Ephesus), for courage under pressure (Smyrna), for undivided loyalty (Pergamum), for discernment with love (Thyatira). Let each reporter pray for “their” church and then for our own church in the same matter. Close with 2:25: “Only hold fast to what you have until I come.”

NOTES FOR THE LEADER

- This session covers four devotionals (days 3–6) and a long chapter. Let each reporter give a two-minute summary of their city from the devotional (Ephesus: Artemis and the emperor temple; Smyrna: Roma, the emperor cult and myrrh; Pergamum: the altar of Zeus, Asclepius and the governor's right of the sword; Thyatira: trade guilds and their idol feasts). If time is short, choose questions 1, 2, 4 and 6.
- Some read the seven churches as seven successive eras of church history. Name this fairly; then point out that the text presents them as real churches of John's day, and that each letter ends with "what the Spirit says to the churches" – every church in every age hears all seven.
- Handle with care: "synagogue of Satan" (2:9) is not a verdict on Jewish people in general. The devotional reads it as a local conflict in which some probably denounced Christians to the authorities; Christ's point is that true belonging to God lies in faith. Do not let the verse be used against Jewish people.
- Handle with care: "Jezebel" is Christ's name for one teacher who led people into idolatry and immorality. It is not a label for women, or for anyone in our church. The letters call us to faithfulness – "whose am I?" – not to judging others.
- "I will move your lampstand" (2:5) is not about an individual losing salvation, but about a church losing its place as a light-bearer. The devotional calls the Nicolaitans a group who allowed compromise with idolatry (cf. 2:14–15); little more is known about them.
- Point ahead: next week chapter 3 – Sardis, Philadelphia and Laodicea. Ask three people to take one church each for next time.

Related devotionals: Day 3 – Ephesus – The Danger of a Dutiful Heart without Love · Day 4 – Smyrna: The Wealth of a Faith Tested by Fire · Day 5 – Pergamum: Where Satan's Throne Is – The Danger of Subtle Compromise · Day 6 – Thyatira: When Tolerance Becomes Betrayal

Revelation 2:1–29

1 To the angel of the church in Ephesus write:
The one who holds the seven stars in his right
hand, who walks among the seven golden
lampstands, says this: 2 I know your works,
your toil and your endurance, and that you can-
not bear evil people. You have tested those who
call themselves apostles and are not, and you
have found them to be liars. 3 You have en-
durance, and you have borne up for my name's
sake, and you have not grown weary. 4 But I
have this against you: you have abandoned your
first love. 5 So remember from where you have
fallen, repent, and do the first works. If not, I
am coming to you, and I will move your lamp-
stand from its place, unless you repent. 6 But
you have this: you hate the works of the
Nicolaitans, which I also hate. 7 Whoever has
an ear should hear what the Spirit says to the
churches. To the one who conquers I will give
to eat from the tree of life, which is in the par-
adise of God.

8 And to the angel of the church in Smyrna
write: The First and the Last, who was dead and
came to life, says this: 9 I know your affliction
and your poverty – but you are rich – and the
slander of those who say they are Jews and are
not, but are a synagogue of Satan. 10 Do not fear
anything you are about to suffer. Look, the
devil is about to throw some of you into prison
so that you may be tested, and you will have af-
fliction for ten days. Be faithful to the point of
death, and I will give you the crown of life.
11 Whoever has an ear should hear what the
Spirit says to the churches. The one who con-
quers will not be harmed at all by the second
death.

12 And to the angel of the church in Pergamum
write: The one who has the sharp two-edged
sword says this: 13 I know where you live: where
the throne of Satan is. Yet you hold fast to my
name, and you did not deny your faith in me,
even in the days of Antipas, my witness, my
faithful one, who was killed among you, where
Satan lives. 14 But I have a few things against
you: you have people there who hold fast to the
teaching of Balaam, who taught Balak to put a
stumbling block before the people of Israel, so
that they would eat food sacrificed to idols and
commit sexual immorality. 15 So you too have
people who in the same way hold fast to the
teaching of the Nicolaitans. 16 So repent. If not,
I am coming to you soon, and I will make war
against them with the sword of my mouth.
17 Whoever has an ear should hear what the
Spirit says to the churches. To the one who con-
quers I will give some of the hidden manna,
and I will give him a white stone, and on the
stone a new name is written that no one knows
except the one who receives it.

18 And to the angel of the church in Thyatira
write: The Son of God, who has eyes like a flame
of fire and whose feet are like burnished
bronze, says this: 19 I know your works: your
love and faith and service and endurance, and
that your last works are more than the first.
20 But I have this against you: you tolerate the
woman Jezebel, who calls herself a prophetess
and teaches and deceives my servants, so that
they commit sexual immorality and eat food
sacrificed to idols. 21 I gave her time to repent,
but she does not want to repent of her sexual
immorality. 22 Look, I am throwing her onto a
bed, and those who commit adultery with her
into great affliction, unless they repent of her
works. 23 And I will kill her children with pesti-
lence. And all the churches will know that I am
the one who searches minds and hearts, and I
will give to each of you according to your
works. 24 But to the rest of you in Thyatira, all
who do not hold this teaching, who have not
come to know the deep things of Satan, as they
call them, I say: I am not putting any other bur-
den on you. 25 Only hold fast to what you have

until I come. [26] And the one who conquers and keeps my works to the end, I will give him authority over the nations,

[27] and he will shepherd them with an iron rod,
as clay pots are shattered –

[28] just as I too have received it from my Father.
And I will give him the morning star.
[29] Whoever has an ear should hear what the Spirit says to the churches.

SESSION 3 · REVELATION 3:1–22

Wake Up, Hold Fast, Open the Door

THE BIG IDEA

Christ sees past reputation, size and wealth: he wakes up a church that only looks alive, opens a door for a church with little power, and knocks at the door of a church that thinks it needs nothing – and to all three he offers a place with him on his throne.

TO GET STARTED

What is the difference between a house that looks good in photos and a house that is good to live in? Have you ever been surprised by the difference?

TIMING

10 min	Welcome & opener
15 min	Read the passage
10 min	Background & original language
40 min	Discussion
15 min	Application & prayer

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 3:1–22

Let the three members who each took a church read their letter (vv. 1–6, 7–13, 14–22); the whole group reads the refrain together. At the end, let one person read verse 20 again slowly, and keep a moment of silence.

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

The messenger's road ends with three more cities. Sardis was proud of its past and of a citadel it thought impregnable – yet it was taken twice because no one kept watch. Philadelphia was young and small, on a fertile plain shaken again and again by earthquakes. Laodicea was rich, with banks, a textile trade and a medical school, but its water arrived lukewarm. Three churches, three dangers – reputation, weakness, comfort – and the seven letters end with a throne (3:21).

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

- ***onoma* – ὄνομα** "name": Name means reputation: "you have the name of being alive, but you are dead" (3:1). Sardis was well known, active and respected – and before Christ a fine gravestone with an impressive inscription. Yet the same letter also knows "a few names" who have not soiled their clothes (3:4).
- ***mikran dynamin* – μικρὰν δύναμιν** "little power": Not a rebuke for weak faith, but a description of a small, poor church without influence (3:8). And yet it kept Christ's word and did not deny his name – and the one who holds the key of David set an open door before it.
- ***chliaros* – χλιαρός** "lukewarm": The word occurs only here in the New Testament (3:16). Many interpreters hear the water of the Lycus valley behind it: hot, healing springs at Hierapolis, cold drinking water at Colossae – and lukewarm water at Laodicea that healed no one and quenched no one's thirst.

DISCUSSION

1. Each reporter: what did your city pride itself on (Sardis: its unconquerable citadel; Philadelphia: its name and its new imperial names; Laodicea: its banks, its black wool and its eye-salve)? Where does Christ's letter touch exactly that point? (Revelation 3:1–18)
2. Sardis: "you have the name of being alive, but you are dead." No persecution, no false teacher – can peace with the world be a sign of spiritual sleep? How wide is the gap between your "name" and your life with God when no one is watching – and what would "Wake up, and strengthen what remains" mean for you? (Revelation 3:1–4)

3. Philadelphia: Christ has “the key of David, who opens and no one will shut, and who shuts and no one opens” (Isaiah 22:20–23). What did that key mean for Eliakim, and what does it mean that Jesus holds it? Which door has been shut in your face – and which door may he have opened? (Revelation 3:7–8)
4. “You have little power, and yet you have kept my word and have not denied my name.” What does this say to small churches and to people who feel too ordinary to matter? Why would a pillar “in the temple of my God” mean so much in a city of earthquakes? (Revelation 3:8–12)
5. “I too will keep you from the hour of testing”. The devotional points to John 17:15: not taken out of the world, but kept from the evil one – kept through it and brought out of it. What difference does it make whether we expect God to spare us trouble or to keep us in it? (Revelation 3:10–11)
6. Laodicea: “I am rich, I have become wealthy, and I need nothing”. Christ offers to sell what only he has (cf. Isaiah 55:1: buy without money and without price). Where has comfort or success made you feel, without noticing, that you need nothing? What would gold refined by fire, white clothes and salve for your eyes be for you? (Revelation 3:15–19)
7. “Look, I am standing at the door and knocking.” The Lord of the church stands outside his own church – and does not break the door down. Which room of your life is he still knocking at? And what does it mean that the one who opens is invited to sit with him on his throne? (Revelation 3:20–22)

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- Choose one spiritual habit that is “about to die” in your life – prayer, Bible reading, worship, generosity – and strengthen it deliberately this week, at a fixed time each day.
- Open a door: name the area of your life where Jesus is still standing outside, tell him so in prayer, and give him the place of honour there – perhaps with one concrete change in how you spend your time or your money.

PRAY TOGETHER

Pray for the three churches and for ourselves: for wakefulness (Sardis), for faithfulness with little power (Philadelphia), for honest dependence (Laodicea). Then keep a minute of silence with verse 20, and let each person open one door to Christ in silence. Close by thanking him that he loves those he reproves (3:19).

NOTES FOR THE LEADER

- This session covers three devotionals (days 7–9). Let each reporter introduce their city in two minutes from the devotional (Sardis: the citadel taken by Cyrus and by Antiochus; Philadelphia: the earthquake of AD 17; Laodicea: the earthquake of AD 60, its banks, wool, eye-salve and lukewarm water). If time is short, choose questions 2, 3, 6 and 7.
- 3:10 and the "rapture": some (especially dispensational readings) take 3:10 as a promise that the church will be taken away before a future time of affliction. Name this fairly. The devotional reads "keep you from" as kept through and brought out of it, as in John 17:15 – for Philadelphia and for every church. Do not let the evening become a debate about it.
- Hot and cold: the older reading takes "hot" as zealous and "cold" as hostile. The devotional prefers the background of Hierapolis and Colossae, in which both hot and cold are useful – but it says we cannot be certain. Either way the point is the same: lukewarm faith is useless.
- Handle with care: someone may fear for their name in the book of life. Verse 5 is a promise, not a threat: "I will never blot his name out of the book of life". Let the anxious hear the promise. The same care as last week applies to "the synagogue of Satan" (3:9).
- Verse 20 is often used in evangelism, and it can be heard that way – but in context Christ speaks to a church that has shut him out. Let the group hear both.
- Point ahead: the letters end with a throne (3:21), and next week "a door stood open in heaven" (4:1) – we shall see who sits on that throne, and who stands in the middle of it.

Related devotionals: Day 7 – Sardis – The Danger of a Good Reputation Without a Beating Heart · Day 8 – Philadelphia – Little Power, but an Open Door No One Can Shut · Day 9 – Laodicea – The Danger of Lukewarm Faith and the King Who Knocks at the Door

Revelation 3:1–22

1 And to the angel of the church in Sardis write:
The one who has the seven spirits of God and
the seven stars says this: I know your works:
you have the name of being alive, but you are
dead. 2 Wake up, and strengthen what remains,
which was about to die, for I have not found
your works complete before my God. 3 So re-
member how you received and heard; keep it,
and repent. If you do not wake up, I will come
like a thief, and you will not know at all at what
hour I will come upon you. 4 But you have a few
names in Sardis who have not soiled their
clothes, and they will walk with me in white,
because they are worthy. 5 The one who con-
quers will in this way be dressed in white
clothes, and I will never blot his name out of
the book of life, and I will confess his name be-
fore my Father and before his angels. 6 Whoever
has an ear should hear what the Spirit says to
the churches.

7 And to the angel of the church in Philadelphia
write: The Holy One, the True One, who has the
key of David, who opens and no one will shut,
and who shuts and no one opens, says this: 8 I
know your works – look, I have set before you
an open door, which no one is able to shut – that
you have little power, and yet you have kept my
word and have not denied my name. 9 Look, I
will give you some from the synagogue of
Satan, who say they are Jews and are not, but
are lying – look, I will make them come and
bow down before your feet, and they will know
that I have loved you. 10 Because you have kept
the word of my endurance, I too will keep you
from the hour of testing that is about to come
on the whole world, to test those who live on
the earth. 11 I am coming soon. Hold fast to what
you have, so that no one takes your crown.
12 The one who conquers, I will make him a pil-
lar in the temple of my God, and he will never
go out of it again. And I will write on him the
name of my God and the name of the city of my
God, the new Jerusalem, which comes down
out of heaven from my God, and my new name.
13 Whoever has an ear should hear what the
Spirit says to the churches.

14 And to the angel of the church in Laodicea
write: The Amen, the faithful and true witness,
the beginning of God's creation, says this: 15 I
know your works: you are neither cold nor hot.
I wish you were cold or hot! 16 So, because you
are lukewarm, and neither hot nor cold, I am
about to vomit you out of my mouth. 17 For you
say: I am rich, I have become wealthy, and I
need nothing – and you do not know that it is
you who are wretched and pitiable and poor
and blind and naked. 18 I advise you to buy from
me gold refined by fire, so that you may become
rich, and white clothes to put on, so that the
shame of your nakedness may not be exposed,
and salve to put on your eyes, so that you may
see. 19 All those I love, I reprove and discipline.
So be zealous and repent. 20 Look, I am standing
at the door and knocking. If anyone hears my
voice and opens the door, I will come in to him
and eat with him, and he with me. 21 The one
who conquers, I will give him the right to sit
with me on my throne, just as I too conquered
and sat down with my Father on his throne.
22 Whoever has an ear should hear what the
Spirit says to the churches.

SESSION 4 · REVELATION 4:1 – 5:14

Who Is Worthy?

THE BIG IDEA

Behind the visible power of Rome John is shown the throne in heaven, where the Creator is worshipped, and in the middle of the throne a Lamb standing, as though slaughtered: God rules history, and his power looks like the cross.

TIMING

10 min	Welcome & opener
10 min	Read the passage
10 min	Background & original language
40 min	Discussion
15 min	Application & prayer

TO GET STARTED

Have you ever heard someone described before you met them – and then been completely surprised when you saw them? What had you expected?

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 4:1 – 5:14

One narrator reads John's words; others read the songs: the four living creatures (4:8), the elders (4:11 and 5:9–10), the angels (5:12). The whole group reads the song of every creature together (5:13) and answers with the living creatures: "Amen."

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

In the cities of the seven churches Rome's throne was visible everywhere: temples for the emperor, his image on coins and in the market squares; Pergamum was the place "where the throne of Satan is" (2:13). After the seven letters a door opens in heaven, and the curtain is drawn back: chapter 4 shows the throne where the Creator is worshipped, chapter 5 the sealed scroll and the Lamb who alone is worthy to open it. Everything that follows in the book – seals, trumpets, bowls – comes from this room.

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

- ***axios ei* – Ἄξιος εἶ** "worthy are you": According to Suetonius, the emperor Domitian wished to be addressed as "our lord and god". In the elders' song – "Worthy are you, our Lord and God" (4:11) – many hear a quiet, courageous counter-voice. In 5:9 the same words are sung to the Lamb: he receives the worship that belongs to God.
- ***arnion* – ἀρνίον** "Lamb": With one exception (the beast of 13:11) John uses this word only for Christ – 29 times. Behind it stand the Passover lamb of Exodus 12 and the Servant led like a lamb to the slaughter (Isaiah 53:7). The Lamb is standing "as though slaughtered" (hōs esphagmenon): alive, but still bearing the wounds (5:6).
- ***ēgorasas* – ἠγόρασας** "you purchased": A word of the market, which could also describe buying slaves (5:9). By his blood the Lamb has bought people for God from every nation and made them a kingdom and priests – what God promised Israel at Sinai (Exodus 19:6).

DISCUSSION

1. After Christ knocking at a closed door in Laodicea, now "a door stood open in heaven", and John hears "Come up here". What would it mean for believers in cities full of emperor temples to be shown the throne first – before any seals or plagues? Does your day usually begin with the news or with the throne? (Revelation 4:1–2)
2. John stands in a long line. Read Isaiah 6:1–3, Ezekiel 1:26–28 and Job 1:6–12 (or 1 Kings 22:19). What do these scenes behind the curtain have in common? What do they say about who really decides what hap-

pens on earth – and about the accuser, who can do nothing without God's permission? (Revelation 4:2–8)

3. The elders sing "Worthy are you, our Lord and God" – the very title Domitian claimed – and the reason is creation: "for you created all things". In your decisions about time, money and attention, what do you actually call "worthy"? (Revelation 4:9–11)
4. The elders cast their crowns before the throne. What "crown" are you holding tightly – a title, an achievement, your reputation, even your own faithfulness? What freedom might there be in laying it down? (Revelation 4:10)
5. John weeps, because no one is found worthy to open the scroll. These are the tears of every believer who wonders whether suffering has any meaning. Which "scroll" in your life seems closed and sealed? And what does it mean that the golden bowls of incense "are the prayers of the saints"? (Revelation 5:1–8)
6. John hears "the Lion from the tribe of Judah, the Root of David, has conquered" – and sees "a Lamb standing, as though slaughtered". What did people expect from the Lion? What does it mean that the seeing interprets the hearing – that God's power looks like the cross? Where do you long for a Lion rather than the Lamb? (Revelation 5:5–7)
7. "by your blood you purchased people for God from every tribe and language and people and nation" – and "they reign on the earth", in the present tense. How does the Lamb's people reign: like their King, by witness and self-giving love? What would that look like in one conflict or frustration of yours this week? (Revelation 5:9–14)

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- Each morning this week, before you unlock your phone, read 4:8–11 aloud. Then name one "throne" that frightens you at the moment and deliberately lay it before the throne on which he sits.
- Choose one place where you would love to "roar" – a conflict, an injustice, a frustration – and ask: how would the Lamb conquer here? Then take one small step of self-giving love in that direction.

PRAY TOGETHER

Begin with worship, not requests: read the songs of 4:8, 4:11 and 5:12 aloud together (or sing a song based on them). Then let each person name one "sealed scroll" and place it in the hands of the Lamb, trusting that our prayers are kept before the throne. Close by reading 5:13 together and answering "Amen."

NOTES FOR THE LEADER

- This session covers two devotionals (days 10–11) and two chapters. The heart of the evening is 5:5–6 (question 6): John hears “Lion” and sees a Lamb. Keep time for it; it is the key to everything that follows in the series.
- Some (especially dispensational readings) take “Come up here” (4:1) as a picture of the church being taken up before the events of chapters 6–19, partly because the word “church” does not appear again until 22:16. Name this fairly. The devotional reads it as a call to John, like the prophets before him, to see the present reality behind the curtain. Keep the focus on the throne and the Lamb.
- The twenty-four elders are probably the whole people of God – twelve tribes and twelve apostles (cf. 21:12–14) – though others think of angelic beings. The four living creatures recall Ezekiel's cherubim and Isaiah's seraphim and probably represent the whole of living creation. Mention briefly; do not spend long.
- The scroll probably stands for God's purpose for history – his judgement on evil and the coming of his kingdom. Do not try to decode the seals yet; that is next session (chapters 6–7).
- Handle with care: “the Lamb conquers by self-giving love” must not be heard as “put up with abuse”. The Lamb's way is faithful witness and refusing to hit back – not staying silent in harm or leaving the vulnerable unprotected. If someone in the group is in a harmful situation, talk with them afterwards.
- Plan the prayer time as worship. Revelation 4–5 is full of songs; if your group sings, choose a hymn or song based on these chapters.

Related devotionals: Day 10 – A Door Open in Heaven: The Throne Behind the Curtain · Day 11 – The Lion Who Is a Lamb: The Key to Revelation

Revelation 4:1 – 5:14

1 After this I looked, and look, a door stood open
in heaven, and the first voice, which I had
heard speaking with me like a trumpet, said,
"Come up here, and I will show you what must
take place after this." 2 At once I was in the
Spirit. And look, a throne stood in heaven, and
on the throne someone was seated. 3 And the
one seated there looked like jasper and car-
nelian, and around the throne was a rainbow
that looked like an emerald. 4 And around the
throne were twenty-four thrones, and on the
thrones sat twenty-four elders, dressed in white
clothes, with golden crowns on their heads.
5 And from the throne come lightning and
sounds and thunder, and seven torches of fire
are burning before the throne; these are the
seven spirits of God. 6 And before the throne
there was something like a sea of glass, like
crystal. And in the middle of the throne and
around the throne were four living creatures,
full of eyes in front and behind. 7 The first living
creature was like a lion, the second living crea-
ture was like a young bull, the third living crea-
ture had a face like a human being, and the
fourth living creature was like a flying eagle.
8 And the four living creatures, each of them
with six wings, are full of eyes all around and
within. And day and night they never rest,
saying:

Holy, holy, holy is the Lord God, the Almighty,
who was and who is and who is coming.

9 And whenever the living creatures give glory
and honour and thanks to the one seated on the
throne, who lives for ever and ever, 10 the
twenty-four elders fall down before the one
seated on the throne and worship the one who
lives for ever and ever, and they cast their
crowns before the throne, saying:

11 Worthy are you, our Lord and God,
to receive the glory and the honour and the
power,
for you created all things,
and by your will they existed and were created.

1 And I saw in the right hand of the one seated
on the throne a scroll written inside and on the
back, sealed with seven seals. 2 And I saw a
mighty angel proclaiming with a loud voice,
"Who is worthy to open the scroll and to break
its seals?" 3 And no one in heaven or on earth or
under the earth was able to open the scroll or to
look into it. 4 And I wept and wept, because no
one was found worthy to open the scroll or to
look into it. 5 And one of the elders says to me,
"Do not weep. Look, the Lion from the tribe of
Judah, the Root of David, has conquered, so
that he can open the scroll and its seven seals."

6 And I saw in the middle of the throne and of
the four living creatures, and in the middle of
the elders, a Lamb standing, as though slaugh-
tered. He had seven horns and seven eyes,
which are the seven spirits of God sent out into
all the earth. 7 And he came and took it out of
the right hand of the one seated on the throne.
8 And when he had taken the scroll, the four liv-
ing creatures and the twenty-four elders fell
down before the Lamb, each holding a lyre and
golden bowls full of incense, which are the
prayers of the saints. 9 And they sing a new
song:

Worthy are you to take the scroll
and to open its seals,
for you were slaughtered,
and by your blood you purchased people for
God
from every tribe and language and people and
nation,
10 and you made them a kingdom and priests to
our God,
and they reign on the earth.

11 And I looked, and I heard the voice of many
angels around the throne and the living crea-
tures and the elders, and their number was ten

thousands of ten thousands and thousands of thousands, [12] saying with a loud voice:

Worthy is the Lamb who was slaughtered
to receive the power and wealth and wisdom and strength
and honour and glory and praise.

[13] And every creature in heaven and on earth
and under the earth and on the sea, and everything in them, I heard saying:

To the one seated on the throne and to the Lamb
be the praise and the honour and the glory and the might
for ever and ever.

[14] And the four living creatures said, "Amen."
And the elders fell down and worshipped.

SESSION 5 · REVELATION 6:1 – 7:17

Who Can Stand?

THE BIG IDEA

The Lamb who was slaughtered holds the seals: war, hunger and death ride out only when he opens them and only as far as God allows – and to the great question "who can stand?" the answer is a countless crowd from every nation, sealed by God and washed in the blood of the Lamb.

TO GET STARTED

When you hear bad news on the radio or read it on your phone, what is your first reaction – switch off, worry, look for an explanation, or pray? Why?

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 6:1 – 7:17

One narrator reads the chapters; at each seal the whole group says "Come!" together (6:1, 3, 5, 7). A second reader takes the cry of the souls (6:10) and the elder (7:13–17); everyone reads the songs of 7:10 and 7:12 together.

TIMING

10 min	Welcome & opener
10 min	Read the passage
10 min	Background & original language
40 min	Discussion
15 min	Application & prayer

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

In chapters 4–5 John saw the throne in heaven and the Lamb who alone is worthy to take the scroll. Now the Lamb opens the seals one by one: four riders, the souls under the altar, and a sky rolled up like a scroll (chapter 6). For the small churches in Asia, who knew war, famine and the pressure of Rome, this was no fantasy. Before the seventh seal the story pauses (chapter 7): God seals his servants, and John sees the crowd that no one could count.

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

- ***edothē* – ἐδόθη** "was given": The crown, the sword and the authority are given to the riders (6:2, 4, 8). The passive points to God as the one who permits – and limits: the oil and the wine are spared, Death is given a fourth of the earth, not the whole. As in Job 1–2, the destroyer can go only as far as God allows.
- ***stathēnai* / *hestōtes* – σταθῆναι / ἑστῶτες** "stand / standing": Chapter 6 ends with the question of Nahum 1:6: "who can stand?" (6:17). Chapter 7 answers it: a crowd "standing before the throne and before the Lamb" (7:9) – not in their own strength, but because the Lamb himself stood first, "as though slaughtered" (5:6).
- ***sphragida* – σφραγῖδα** "seal": A seal was the mark of ownership and authenticity – a signet ring in the wax of a letter, a stamp on a cargo. What is sealed belongs to someone and is guarded by him. God's servants are sealed on their foreheads before the storm comes (7:3).

DISCUSSION

1. Each rider comes out only when the Lamb opens a seal, and each time something is given: "a crown was given to him", "a great sword was given to him". Which of the riders – war, economic pressure, illness, death – frightens you most at the moment? What changes when you remember who opens the seals? (Revelation 6:1–8)
2. Compare verse 8 with Zechariah 1:8–11 and Ezekiel 14:21. Jesus said that wars and famines would mark the whole time until his return, but that this is not yet the end (Mark 13:7–8). So how should we read

the seals – as a timetable, or as a picture of the world between Christ's first and second coming? (Revelation 6:8)

3. The souls under the altar cry out: "How long, holy and true Master, will you not judge and avenge our blood on those who live on the earth?" God does not rebuke them but tells them "to rest a little longer". What does this say about honest prayer? What have you long been crying "How long?" about? (Revelation 6:9–11)

4. Kings, generals and the rich hide in the caves – but also "every slave and free person". They hide "from the wrath of the Lamb". How can the wrath of the one who was slaughtered for the world be both the most serious and the most hopeful word in the chapter? On whom or what are you relying to stand on that day? (Revelation 6:15–17)

5. Before the storm God's servants are sealed on their foreheads (compare Exodus 12:13; Ezekiel 9:4–6). In Asia the emperor cult and the trade guilds asked every day whom the believers belonged to – what comfort lay in this seal? Which labels that others stick on you do you believe more than the seal of the living God? (Revelation 7:1–3)

6. John hears a number – a hundred and forty-four thousand from the tribes of Israel – and then sees "a great crowd that no one could count, from every nation and all tribes and peoples and languages". How does this fulfil God's promise to Abraham (Genesis 15:5; 12:3)? How big is the church in your imagination? (Revelation 7:4–10)

7. "They have washed their robes and made them white in the blood of the Lamb." The crowd sings not about its endurance but "To our God, who sits on the throne, and to the Lamb belongs salvation!" Where are you still trying to keep your robes clean yourself? Which promise of verses 15–17 do you need most this week? (Revelation 7:13–17)

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- When you read or hear the news this week, choose one place of war or hunger and pray for it – and say it aloud: the Lamb holds the seals in his hand.
- Each morning when you see your face in the mirror, tell yourself: I am sealed, and I belong to the Lamb. Pray once this week for believers in a country and a language that are not your own.

PRAY TOGETHER

Begin with the song of the crowd, read aloud together: "To our God, who sits on the throne, and to the Lamb belongs salvation!" (7:10). Then let each person name, in a sentence, one "How long?" before God – for themselves or for suffering believers elsewhere. Close by thanking God that "God will wipe away every tear from their eyes".

NOTES FOR THE LEADER

- This session covers two devotionals (days 12–13). Chapter 6 is frightening and chapter 7 is its answer – don't let the discussion get stuck in chapter 6. Keep at least fifteen minutes for chapter 7.
- Our approach in this series: the seals show the world as it is between Christ's first and second coming, and who holds it in his hand; only the sixth seal takes us up to the great day itself. Futurist interpreters place the seals in a future period just before Christ's return. If this comes up, name it fairly in a sentence and return to the pastoral point: the Lamb opens the seals, and history is not out of control.
- The first rider (6:2): some see Christ himself, since he rides a white horse in 19:11; many read him as conquest and war, perhaps even as a counterfeit of Christ, because he rides out with the other three. Both readings can be mentioned; don't spend long on it.
- The 144,000: dispensationalists read them literally as Jewish believers, distinct from the crowd. The pattern of hearing and seeing (as in 5:5–6) makes it likely that John describes one people from two sides. Israel is not wiped out or replaced; the nations are grafted into Abraham's family (Romans 11:17–18; Galatians 3:29). Keep the tone warm – no polemics.
- Handle with care: the group may include people who are grieving or who have family in countries of war or persecution. Let the cry “How long?” be heard without rushing to answers, and resist any attempt to match the riders to today's headlines or to work out dates.
- Point ahead: next week the seventh seal – silence in heaven, the prayers of the saints, and the trumpets.

Related devotionals: Day 12 – The Lamb Opens the Seals: Who Can Stand? · Day 13 – Sealed on the Forehead: The Crowd No One Could Count

Revelation 6:1 – 7:17

1 And I saw when the Lamb opened one of the
seven seals, and I heard one of the four living
creatures say with a voice like thunder, "Come!"
2 And I looked, and there was a white horse, and
its rider had a bow; and a crown was given to
him, and he went out conquering and to
conquer.

3 And when he opened the second seal, I heard
the second living creature say, "Come!" 4 And
another horse came out, fiery red; and its rider
was allowed to take peace from the earth, so
that people would slaughter one another; and a
great sword was given to him.

5 And when he opened the third seal, I heard
the third living creature say, "Come!" And I
looked, and there was a black horse, and its
rider had a pair of scales in his hand. 6 And I
heard something like a voice in the middle of
the four living creatures, saying, "A quart of
wheat for a denarius, and three quarts of barley
for a denarius, but do not harm the oil and the
wine!"

7 And when he opened the fourth seal, I heard
the voice of the fourth living creature say,
"Come!" 8 And I looked, and there was a pale
green horse, and the name of its rider was
Death, and Hades followed with him. And they
were given authority over a fourth of the earth,
to kill with sword and with famine and with
pestilence and by the wild beasts of the earth.

9 And when he opened the fifth seal, I saw under
the altar the souls of those who had been
slaughtered because of the word of God and be-
cause of the testimony they had. 10 And they
cried out with a loud voice, "How long, holy and
true Master, will you not judge and avenge our
blood on those who live on the earth?" 11 And
each of them was given a white robe, and they
were told to rest a little longer, until their fel-
low servants and their brothers and sisters,
who were about to be killed as they themselves
had been, were complete in number.

12 And I saw when he opened the sixth seal:
there was a great earthquake, and the sun be-
came black like sackcloth made of hair, and the
whole moon became like blood, 13 and the stars
of the sky fell to the earth, as a fig tree drops its
unripe figs when it is shaken by a strong wind.
14 And the sky receded like a scroll being rolled
up, and every mountain and island was moved
from its place. 15 And the kings of the earth and
the nobles and the generals and the rich and the
powerful and every slave and free person hid
themselves in the caves and among the rocks of
the mountains, 16 and they say to the mountains
and the rocks, "Fall on us and hide us from the
face of the one seated on the throne and from
the wrath of the Lamb, 17 for the great day of
their wrath has come, and who can stand?"

1 After this I saw four angels standing at the four
corners of the earth, holding back the four
winds of the earth, so that no wind would blow
on the earth or on the sea or on any tree. 2 And I
saw another angel coming up from the rising of
the sun, with the seal of the living God. And he
cried out with a loud voice to the four angels
who had been allowed to harm the earth and
the sea, 3 saying, "Do not harm the earth or the
sea or the trees until we have sealed the ser-
vants of our God on their foreheads."

4 And I heard the number of those who were
sealed: a hundred and forty-four thousand,
sealed from every tribe of the people of Israel:
5 from the tribe of Judah twelve thousand
sealed, from the tribe of Reuben twelve thou-
sand, from the tribe of Gad twelve thousand,
6 from the tribe of Asher twelve thousand, from
the tribe of Naphtali twelve thousand, from the
tribe of Manasseh twelve thousand, 7 from the
tribe of Simeon twelve thousand, from the tribe
of Levi twelve thousand, from the tribe of

Issachar twelve thousand, [8] from the tribe of Zebulun twelve thousand, from the tribe of Joseph twelve thousand, from the tribe of Benjamin twelve thousand sealed.

[9] After this I looked, and look, a great crowd that no one could count, from every nation and all tribes and peoples and languages, standing before the throne and before the Lamb, dressed in white robes, with palm branches in their hands. [10] And they cry out with a loud voice:

To our God, who sits on the throne, and to the
Lamb belongs salvation!

[11] And all the angels stood around the throne and around the elders and the four living creatures, and they fell on their faces before the throne and worshipped God, [12] saying:

Amen! The praise and the glory and the wisdom
and the thanksgiving and the honour and the
power and the strength
be to our God for ever and ever. Amen.

[13] And one of the elders spoke up and said to me, "These who are dressed in white robes – who are they, and where have they come from?" [14] And I said to him, "My lord, you know." And he said to me: These are the ones who are coming out of the great affliction; they have washed their robes and made them white in the blood of the Lamb.

[15] That is why they are before the throne of God
and serve him day and night in his temple,
and the one seated on the throne will spread his
tent over them.
[16] They will hunger no more and thirst no more,
and the sun will not strike them, nor any
scorching heat,
[17] for the Lamb in the middle of the throne will
shepherd them
and lead them to springs of the water of life,
and God will wipe away every tear from their
eyes.

SESSION 6 · REVELATION 8:1 – 9:21

Heaven Is Listening

THE BIG IDEA

Heaven falls silent to hear the prayers of the saints, and those prayers come back to earth as God's action; the trumpets, like the plagues of Egypt, are limited warnings that call the world to repent – but judgement alone does not change the heart, and what the plagues cannot do, the Lamb does through his witnesses.

TO GET STARTED

Where do you find real silence in your week – and do you enjoy it, or does it make you uneasy?

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 8:1 – 9:21

Begin with half a minute of silence after 8:1 before reading on. Then one narrator reads, and six readers each take one trumpet (8:7, 8, 10, 12; 9:1, 13); a last reader takes the eagle's cry (8:13) and 9:20–21.

TIMING

10 min	Welcome & opener
10 min	Read the passage
10 min	Background & original language
40 min	Discussion
15 min	Application & prayer

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

Heaven has been full of songs: angels, elders, living creatures and a countless crowd. Now the Lamb opens the seventh seal – and there is silence. An angel offers incense with the prayers of all the saints, throws fire from the altar on the earth, and seven trumpets sound (chapters 8–9). The images come from the exodus: hail, blood, darkness and locusts, as in Egypt. For the small churches in Asia, under the power of Rome, this said: God still acts against every empire that behaves like Egypt.

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

- ***sigē* – σιγὴ** "silence": An ordinary word for silence (8:1). It is not an empty silence, but the silence of a courtroom before the judge speaks – and of a Father who is listening. The prophets knew it as the silence before God acts (Habakkuk 2:20; Zephaniah 1:7).
- ***to triton* – τὸ τρίτον** "a third": Twelve times in six verses (8:7–12). The seals struck a fourth (6:8), the trumpets a third, the bowls later everything. The judgements are limited. They are warnings, not yet the end.
- ***ou metenoēsan* – οὐ μετενόησαν** "they did not repent": *Metanoeō* is a turning round of mind and life (9:20–21). It is the same verb Jesus used five times for the churches (2:5, 16, 21; 3:3, 19): the call to repent is addressed first to the church, then to the world.

DISCUSSION

1. "There was silence in heaven for about half an hour." Read Habakkuk 2:20 and Zephaniah 1:7. What kind of silence is this? When did you last become truly still before God, without speaking? (Revelation 8:1)
2. The angel stands at the golden altar of incense, right in front of the curtain (Exodus 30:1–8; Luke 1:9–10), and the incense rises "with the prayers of the saints" before God. What does this picture say to small churches whose prayers no one in Rome heard – and to you, if you have given up on a prayer? (Revelation 8:3–4)
3. The angel fills the censer "with the fire of the altar" and throws it on the earth – the same altar under which the souls cried "How long?" (6:9–10). Then the trumpets begin. Do you believe that your prayers are part of how God acts in the world? How would that change your intercession? (Revelation 8:5–6)

4. Compare the first, second and fourth trumpets with the plagues of Egypt (Exodus 9:23–25; 7:20–21; 10:21–23). What does the exodus tell us about the purpose of the trumpets – for Rome, and for every power that oppresses God's people? What is God aiming at: the destruction of creation, or the liberation of his people? (Revelation 8:7–12)
5. The locusts may harm "only the people who do not have the seal of God on their foreheads". The key, the authority and the five months – all are given. Their king Apollyon ("Destroyer") is perhaps a dig at Apollo. What comfort did this give the churches in Asia? Where do you need to hear that evil is on a leash? (Revelation 9:1–11)
6. "And the rest of humankind … did not even repent of the works of their hands"; like Pharaoh, they cling to idols "which can neither see nor hear nor walk" (Psalm 115:4–8). Which crisis in your life turned you to God – and which made you harder instead? What are the "works of your hands" that you trust more than God? (Revelation 9:20–21)
7. In Israel the trumpet was the watchman's alarm (Ezekiel 33:3–6) – a God who warns has not yet given up on the world. How do you respond to news of disasters – with fear, with speculation, or with prayer and repentance? Do you hear the call to repent as a threat or as an invitation? (Revelation 8:13)

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- Sit in silence for five minutes before you pray, every day this week. Then write down one injustice you have long been praying about, and bring it before God again – knowing that heaven is listening.
- Take ten minutes and ask yourself honestly: which "work of my hands" has taken my heart captive? Name it before God, and take one small step away from it – and towards him.

PRAY TOGETHER

Begin with a full minute of silence together – no words, only remembering who sits on the throne. Then let each person pray one sentence for a situation they have long prayed about, or for persecuted believers. Close with Jesus' words to the churches (3:20), and thank him that he always lives to intercede for us (Hebrews 7:25).

NOTES FOR THE LEADER

- Two dense chapters (days 14–15). Don't try to explain every detail of the locusts or the horses; the chapters work by overwhelming images. Keep the group on three things: the prayers rise, the judgements are limited, and people do not repent.
- Avoid matching the trumpets to today's disasters (or even guessing which trumpet has just sounded). Some interpreters think the first readers may have thought of Vesuvius (AD 79) at the burning mountain; futurist interpreters expect literal plagues in a future period before Christ's return. Mention this fairly if asked, then return to the call to prayer and repentance.
- The locusts and the two hundred million horsemen invite decoding (helicopters, modern armies). Gently point out that John himself says he heard the number (9:16): it is an army too large to grasp, painted with Joel 2 and the smoke of Sodom (Genesis 19:24, 28), not a code.
- Some Bibles read an angel instead of an eagle in 8:13; older translations follow later manuscripts. Our translation follows the SBL Greek text. If someone notices, explain briefly and move on.
- Handle with care: some members may have prayed for years without seeing an answer – for a child, an illness, an injustice. The point of 8:3–5 is not that prayer works like a lever, but that no prayer is lost. Don't promise outcomes.
- Point ahead: next week the pause between the sixth and seventh trumpet – the little scroll and the two witnesses: God's answer to a world that will not repent is his word in the mouth of his witnesses.

Related devotionals: Day 14 – Silence in Heaven: The Prayers of the Saints · Day 15 – Locusts from the Abyss: And They Did Not Repent

Revelation 8:1 – 9:21

1 And when he opened the seventh seal, there
was silence in heaven for about half an hour.
2 And I saw the seven angels who stand before
God, and seven trumpets were given to them.

3 And another angel came and stood at the altar,
holding a golden censer. And much incense was
given to him, so that he would put it with the
prayers of all the saints on the golden altar be-
fore the throne. 4 And the smoke of the incense
went up with the prayers of the saints from the
hand of the angel before God. 5 And the angel
took the censer and filled it with the fire of the
altar and threw it on the earth; and there were
thunder and sounds and lightning and an
earthquake.

6 And the seven angels who had the seven trum-
pets made themselves ready to blow the
trumpet.

7 And the first blew the trumpet; and there
came hail and fire, mixed with blood, and it was
thrown on the earth. And a third of the earth
was burnt up, and a third of the trees were
burnt up, and all the green grass was burnt up.

8 And the second angel blew the trumpet; and
something like a great mountain burning with
fire was thrown into the sea. And a third of the
sea became blood, 9 and a third of the creatures
in the sea that had life died, and a third of the
ships were destroyed.

10 And the third angel blew the trumpet; and a
great star fell from heaven, burning like a
torch, and it fell on a third of the rivers and on
the springs of water. 11 And the name of the star
is called Wormwood. And a third of the waters
became wormwood, and many people died
from the waters, because they had been made
bitter.

12 And the fourth angel blew the trumpet; and a
third of the sun was struck, and a third of the
moon and a third of the stars, so that a third of
them was darkened, and for a third of the day
there was no light, and likewise for the night.

13 And I looked, and I heard an eagle flying in
midheaven, saying with a loud voice, "Woe,
woe, woe to those who live on the earth, be-
cause of the remaining blasts of the trumpet of
the three angels who are about to blow!"

1 And the fifth angel blew the trumpet; and I saw
a star that had fallen from heaven to the earth,
and the key to the shaft of the abyss was given
to him. 2 And he opened the shaft of the abyss,
and smoke went up from the shaft like the
smoke of a great furnace, and the sun and the
air were darkened by the smoke of the shaft.
3 And out of the smoke came locusts onto the
earth, and they were given authority like the
authority that the scorpions of the earth have.
4 And they were told not to harm the grass of
the earth or any green thing or any tree, but
only the people who do not have the seal of God
on their foreheads. 5 And they were allowed not
to kill them, but to torment them for five
months; and their torment was like the tor-
ment of a scorpion when it stings a person.
6 And in those days people will seek death and
will not find it; they will long to die, and death
flees from them.

7 And the shapes of the locusts were like horses
prepared for war; and on their heads was some-
thing like crowns, like gold, and their faces
were like human faces. 8 And they had hair like
women's hair, and their teeth were like lions'
teeth. 9 And they had breastplates like breast-
plates of iron, and the rumble of their wings
was like the rumble of chariots with many
horses rushing into war. 10 And they have tails
like scorpions, and stings, and in their tails is
their authority to harm people for five months.
11 They have as king over them the angel of the
abyss; his name in Hebrew is Abaddon, and in
Greek he has the name Apollyon.

[12] The first woe has passed; look, two woes are still coming after this.

[13] And the sixth angel blew the trumpet; and I heard a voice from the horns of the golden altar that is before God, [14] saying to the sixth angel, who had the trumpet, "Release the four angels who are bound at the great river, the Euphrates!" [15] And the four angels were released, who had been made ready for the hour and day and month and year, to kill a third of humankind. [16] And the number of the mounted troops was twice ten thousands of ten thousands; I heard their number. [17] And this is how I saw the horses in the vision and those who sat on them: they had breastplates fiery red and hyacinth blue and sulphur yellow; and the heads of the horses were like lions' heads, and out of their mouths come fire and smoke and sulphur. [18] By these three plagues a third of humankind was killed, by the fire and the smoke and the sulphur that come out of their mouths. [19] For the authority of the horses is in their mouths and in their tails; for their tails are like serpents, with heads, and with them they do harm.

[20] And the rest of humankind, who were not killed by these plagues, did not even repent of the works of their hands, so as to stop worshipping the demons and the idols of gold and silver and bronze and stone and wood, which can neither see nor hear nor walk. [21] And they did not repent of their murders or of their sorceries or of their sexual immorality or of their thefts.

SESSION 7 · REVELATION 10:1 – 11:19

Sweet and Bitter

THE BIG IDEA

God's answer to a world that will not repent is his word in the mouth of his witnesses: the church eats the word, sweet and bitter, is measured and kept by God, bears witness in sackcloth, shares its Lord's death and resurrection – and the kingdom of the world has already become our Lord's and his Christ's.

TO GET STARTED

Think of a food that you hated as a child but love now (or the other way round). What changed?

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 10:1 – 11:19

Chapter 10: one narrator, one reader for the voice from heaven and the angel (10:4, 8, 9, 11). Chapter 11: one narrator; at 11:12 the whole group says "Come up here!"; everyone reads the songs of 11:15 and 11:17–18 together.

TIMING

10 min	Welcome & opener
10 min	Read the passage
10 min	Background & original language
40 min	Discussion
15 min	Application & prayer

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

After the sixth trumpet we expect the seventh at once. But as between the sixth and the seventh seal, the story pauses. In chapter 7 God's people were sealed; in chapters 10 and 11 they are sent. John eats a little scroll, sweet in the mouth and bitter in the stomach, and must prophesy again; then he measures the temple and sees two witnesses who prophesy, are killed and stand up again. For the churches in Asia, living in Rome's cities, this was their calling: not to withdraw, but to bear witness.

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

- ***chronos ouketi estai* – χρόνος οὐκέτι ἔσται** "there will be no more delay": *Chronos* usually means "time", and older translations read as if time itself would stop. But the oath echoes Daniel 12:7 and answers the "How long?" of 6:10: God will wait no longer (10:6).
- ***kataphage* – κατάφαγε** "eat it up": *Kataphagein* does not mean to taste but to eat up completely (10:9). The word must go into the prophet before it can come out of him – as with Ezekiel, for whom the scroll was sweet as honey and then bitter (Ezekiel 2:8–3:3, 14).
- ***martysin* – μάρτυσίν** "witnesses": We translate "witness", not "martyr" (11:3). But this chapter shows how the two words grew together in the early church: whoever bears faithful witness sometimes pays the price – like Antipas (2:13), and like Jesus himself, "the faithful witness" (1:5).

DISCUSSION

1. Wrapped in a cloud, with a rainbow over his head, the angel sets one foot on the sea and the other on the earth and swears by the one "who created heaven and what is in it, and the earth and what is in it, and the sea and what is in it". What do these images say about whose world this is? (Revelation 10:1–6)
2. John is told: "Seal up what the seven thunders have spoken, and do not write it down!" What does this say to people who use Revelation as a puzzle for dates and speculation? Which questions about the future make you restless – and can you leave them with God? (Revelation 10:4)
3. The souls under the altar were told "to rest a little longer" (6:11). Now the angel swears "that there will be no more delay". Read Habakkuk 2:3. Where have you long been waiting for God, and what does this

oath say to you? (Revelation 10:5–7)

4. Read Ezekiel 3:1–3 and 3:14 alongside Revelation 10:9–10: "Take it and eat it up; it will make your stomach bitter, but in your mouth it will be sweet as honey." Do you read the Bible more like someone who tastes or like someone who eats? Which part of God's word is sweet to you at the moment, and which part bitter? (Revelation 10:8–11)

5. John measures "the temple of God and the altar and those who worship in it", but the outer court is trampled for forty-two months. In the New Testament the church is God's temple (1 Corinthians 3:16). Do you sometimes feel like the court that is trampled? What does it mean to you that God has measured the inner part? (Revelation 11:1–2)

6. "These are the two olive trees and the two lampstands" – and the lampstands are the churches (1:20). Their signs are those of Elijah and Moses, and they stand not by might nor by power, but by God's Spirit (Zechariah 4:6). Where are you tempted to stay silent because your witness would make you unpopular? (Revelation 11:3–10)

7. The witnesses are killed and raised, and – unlike after the plagues (9:20–21) – the rest give glory to the God of heaven – through the testimony. The seventh trumpet sings: "The kingdom of the world has become our Lord's and his Christ's". Where would it make a difference today if you truly believed that? (Revelation 11:11–19)

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- Choose one short passage – Revelation 10:8–11, for example – and read it slowly and aloud every day for three days. "Chew" on it. Then share one sentence from it with someone who needs it.
- Think of one person around you who does not yet know Christ. Pray for him or her by name every day this week, and ask God for one opportunity to share something of your hope – gently, not fearfully.

PRAY TOGETHER

Read 11:15 aloud together. Then pray in pairs: thank God that the kingdom of the world belongs to him and to his Christ; ask him for hunger for his word and courage when witness costs something; pray by name for the person each of you thought of. Close together with Zechariah 4:6: not by might nor by power, but by your Spirit.

NOTES FOR THE LEADER

- Two devotionals (days 16–17). Chapter 11 is one of the hardest in the book; don't let the group get lost in who the two witnesses are. Our reading: they are the witnessing church (the lampstands, 1:20), shown with the features of Moses and Elijah, and two because the law requires two witnesses (Deuteronomy 19:15).
- Other readings: futurist interpreters take the forty-two months as a literal three and a half years at the end of history, with two individual prophets – according to some Moses and Elijah themselves. Name this fairly in a sentence. In this series, the forty-two months / 1,260 days are Daniel's "a time and times and half a time" (Daniel 7:25; 12:7): the measured, limited time of the church's witness between Christ's first and second coming. Don't calculate.
- Some members may know the older rendering of 10:6 ("that there should be time no longer"). The context is about God's waiting, not about the end of the calendar.
- The angel of 10:1 has features of Christ (1:16); some think he is Christ himself, but John calls him an angel. Don't spend long on it.
- Handle with care: some in the group carry the pain of witness that seems in vain – a shrinking congregation, a child far from God, being the only honest one at work. Don't promise success; the chapter promises vindication ("Come up here!"), not popularity.
- Point ahead: next week chapter 12 tells the Christmas story from behind the curtain – and the accuser is thrown down.

Related devotionals: Day 16 – The Little Scroll: Sweet in the Mouth, Bitter in the Stomach · Day 17 – The Two Witnesses: A Testimony Death Cannot Silence

Revelation 10:1 – 11:19

1 And I saw another mighty angel coming down
from heaven, wrapped in a cloud, and the rain-
bow was over his head, and his face was like the
sun, and his feet were like pillars of fire, 2 and
he had in his hand a little scroll, opened. And
he set his right foot on the sea and his left foot
on the earth, 3 and he cried out with a loud
voice, as a lion roars. And when he cried out,
the seven thunders spoke with their own
voices. 4 And when the seven thunders had spo-
ken, I was about to write; and I heard a voice
from heaven saying, "Seal up what the seven
thunders have spoken, and do not write it
down!"

5 And the angel whom I saw standing on the sea
and on the earth raised his right hand to
heaven 6 and swore by the one who lives for
ever and ever, who created heaven and what is
in it, and the earth and what is in it, and the sea
and what is in it, that there will be no more de-
lay, 7 but that in the days of the voice of the sev-
enth angel, when he is about to blow the trum-
pet, the mystery of God is fulfilled, as he an-
nounced the good news to his servants the
prophets.

8 And the voice that I had heard from heaven
spoke with me again and said, "Go, take the
scroll that lies open in the hand of the angel
who is standing on the sea and on the earth."
9 And I went to the angel and told him to give
me the little scroll. And he says to me, "Take it
and eat it up; it will make your stomach bitter,
but in your mouth it will be sweet as honey."
10 And I took the little scroll from the hand of
the angel and ate it up, and it was sweet as
honey in my mouth; and when I had eaten it,
my stomach was made bitter. 11 And they say to
me, "You must prophesy again about many peo-
ples and nations and languages and kings."

1 And a reed like a staff was given to me, and I
was told, "Get up and measure the temple of
God and the altar and those who worship in it.
2 But leave out the court outside the temple, and
do not measure it, for it has been given to the
nations, and they will trample the holy city for
forty-two months. 3 And I will grant my two
witnesses that they prophesy for a thousand
two hundred and sixty days, clothed in
sackcloth."

4 These are the two olive trees and the two lamp-
stands that stand before the Lord of the earth.
5 And if anyone wants to harm them, fire comes
out of their mouth and devours their enemies;
and if anyone should want to harm them, this is
how he must be killed. 6 They have the author-
ity to shut the sky, so that no rain falls during
the days of their prophecy; and they have au-
thority over the waters, to turn them into blood
and to strike the earth with every plague, as of-
ten as they want.

7 And when they have finished their testimony,
the beast that comes up from the abyss will
make war against them and conquer them and
kill them. 8 And their corpse lies in the street of
the great city, which is spiritually called Sodom
and Egypt, where their Lord too was crucified.
9 And people from the peoples and tribes and
languages and nations look at their corpse for
three and a half days, and they do not allow
their corpses to be laid in a tomb. 10 And those
who live on the earth are glad over them and re-
joice, and they will send gifts to one another,
because these two prophets tormented those
who live on the earth.

11 And after the three and a half days a breath of
life from God entered them, and they stood on
their feet, and great fear fell on those who saw
them. 12 And they heard a loud voice from
heaven saying to them, "Come up here!" And
they went up to heaven in the cloud, and their
enemies watched them. 13 And in that hour
there was a great earthquake, and a tenth of the

city fell, and seven thousand people were killed
in the earthquake; and the rest were terrified
and gave glory to the God of heaven.

14 The second woe has passed; look, the third
woe is coming soon.

15 And the seventh angel blew the trumpet; and
there were loud voices in heaven, saying:

The kingdom of the world has become our
    Lord's and his Christ's,
and he will reign for ever and ever.

16 And the twenty-four elders who sit on their
thrones before God fell on their faces and wor-
shipped God, 17 saying:

We give you thanks, Lord God, the Almighty,
who is and who was,
because you have taken your great power
and begun to reign.
18 And the nations were angry,
and your wrath has come,
and the time for the dead to be judged,
and to give the reward to your servants the
    prophets
and to the saints and to those who fear your
    name,
the small and the great,
and to destroy those who destroy the earth.

19 And God's temple in heaven was opened, and
the ark of his covenant was seen in his temple;
and there were lightning and sounds and thun-
der and an earthquake and great hail.

SESSION 8 · REVELATION 12:1 – 13:18

Whose Are You?

THE BIG IDEA

Behind the curtain the dragon has already been thrown down by the blood of the Lamb; in his fury he works through beasts that imitate the Lamb and demand worship – but God's people, sealed before the beast ever appeared, conquer by the blood of the Lamb, the word of their testimony and endurance, for the question is not "when?" but "whose are you?".

TO GET STARTED

Have you ever been fooled by a fake – a counterfeit product, a forged signature, a scam message? How did you find out?

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 12:1 – 13:18

Three readers: a narrator, a second reader for the loud voice in heaven (12:10–12, read slowly as a song of victory), and a third for the crowd and the second beast (13:4, 14). Pause briefly between the two chapters.

TIMING

10 min	Welcome & opener
10 min	Read the passage
10 min	Background & original language
40 min	Discussion
15 min	Application & prayer

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

The seventh trumpet has sounded: the kingdom of the world has become our Lord's. Now John draws the curtain back further and shows how it came about. Chapter 12 tells the Christmas story from behind the curtain: a woman, a child, a dragon – and the accuser thrown down. In chapter 13 the dragon calls up two beasts, from the sea and from the earth. For the churches in Asia the beast had a face: Rome, the imperial cult and the guilds, where you could not buy or sell without offering incense to the emperor.

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

- ***ho katēgōr* – ὁ κατήγωρ** "the accuser": A word from the courtroom (12:10) – exactly what the Hebrew *hassatan* means in Job 1–2 and Zechariah 3: the adversary, the accuser in God's heavenly council. He accuses them "before our God day and night" – but now he has been thrown down.
- ***hōs esphagmenēn* – ὡς ἐσφαγμένην** "seemed slaughtered": The same expression as for the Lamb in 5:6 (*hōs esphagmenon*). John wants us to notice the likeness – and the difference (13:3). The Lamb's wounds are for others; the beast's healing is for itself. Evil creates nothing new. It imitates.
- ***charagma* – χάραγμα** "mark": A stamp or impression – also the emperor's stamp on coins and documents (13:16–17). Every coin in the hand of a trader in Thyatira bore the emperor's image and titles. The mark is "the name of the beast or the number of its name": it says whom you belong to.

DISCUSSION

1. Read Genesis 3:15 and 37:9: what do they tell us about the woman, the child and the dragon? The child "is to shepherd all the nations with an iron rod" (Psalm 2:9) and is "snatched up to God and to his throne" – the whole life of Jesus in one sentence. What is different when we see Bethlehem from behind the curtain? (Revelation 12:1–6)
2. Read Zechariah 3:1–5 and Job 1:9–11: the accuser could still stand before God. Now "the accuser of our brothers and sisters has been thrown down". Which accusation do you hear most often in your own thoughts? How does the Spirit's conviction, which leads to the cross, differ from the accuser's voice, which ends in despair? (Revelation 12:7–10)

3. They conquered “by the blood of the Lamb and by the word of their testimony”, and “they did not love their life even to death”. Do you try to silence the accuser with your own good works, or do you take refuge in the blood of the Lamb? What would it mean for you to speak the word of your testimony? (Revelation 12:11–12)
4. The woman is given “the two wings of the great eagle” and is fed in the wilderness (Exodus 19:4). The church is on its exodus through this age – not out of creation, but out of the dragon's power. Where are you in the wilderness at the moment, and where can you see that God is feeding you there? (Revelation 12:13–18)
5. Read Daniel 7:2–8 and 17: John's beast is leopard, bear and lion in one body. The crowd cries: “Who is like the beast, and who can make war against it?” – a counterfeit of Israel's song (Exodus 15:11). What did the beast look like for the churches in Asia? Which powers lay claim to people's whole heart today? (Revelation 13:1–8)
6. One of its heads “seemed slaughtered to death”, and the second beast “had two horns like a lamb, and it spoke like a dragon”. Why is the convincing copy more dangerous for the church than the open enemy? Where are you drawn by something that looks like a lamb but speaks like a dragon? (Revelation 13:3–15)
7. The mark is given “on their right hand or on their forehead”, and without it no one can buy or sell. Compare God's seal (7:3) and the Shema (Deuteronomy 6:8): what you think and what you do. No one is unmarked. If someone had watched your week: whom do your hand and your forehead belong to? (Revelation 13:16–18)

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- Write down one accusation you hear again and again in your head. Next to it write: “for the accuser of our brothers and sisters has been thrown down” (12:10). Read it aloud when the voice comes back.
- Choose one “hand” choice (something you do) and one “forehead” pattern (something you think) where the beast is pulling at you. Pray about them every day this week with the words: I belong to the Lamb.

PRAY TOGETHER

Read 12:10–11 aloud together. Then let each person thank God in one sentence that they belong to the Lamb, and – if they want to – name one place where they feel the pressure to “buy or sell” by playing along. Close with the confession of the devotional: Who is a God like you? (Micah 7:18), and thank him that our names are written in “the book of life of the slaughtered Lamb” (13:8).

NOTES FOR THE LEADER

- Two devotionals (days 18–19). Both chapters are full of images; spend most of the time on 12:10–11 (the accuser thrown down) and 13:16–17 (the mark). These carry the pastoral weight.
- 666: name the two main readings briefly – the words “Nero Caesar” in Hebrew letters add up to 666 (and in a Latin spelling to 616, the number in a few early manuscripts), or a “human number”, six falling short three times of seven. John calls for the wisdom of discernment, not of code-breakers. Do not decode the number to modern persons, and do not let the group speculate about chips, barcodes or dates.
- The mark is about belonging, not fear. Some members may have grown up with frightening teaching about the mark; reassure them: God's seal came first (7:3), and the mark of the beast is not something you receive by accident – it grows through a thousand small choices of the hand and the forehead.
- Other readings: futurists expect a future individual ruler and a literal mark at the end of history; preterists see the chapter fulfilled in Rome in the first century. Our series: Rome in John's day, and every power in every age that demands worship. Name the views fairly in a sentence and return to the question “whose are you?”.
- “In or out” is a call to faithfulness, not “us against them”. Don't let the group name political parties or leaders as the beast; the question is turned on ourselves first – Laodicea's lukewarm middle way (3:15–16) is also no neutral ground.
- Point ahead: next week chapter 14 – the Lamb on Mount Zion with those who have his name and his Father's name on their foreheads.

Related devotionals: Day 18 – The Accuser Is Thrown Down: The Christmas Story from Behind the Curtain · Day 19 – The Mark of the Beast: Whose Are You?

Revelation 12:1 – 13:18

1 And a great sign appeared in heaven: a woman
clothed with the sun, with the moon under her
feet, and on her head a crown of twelve stars.
2 And she was pregnant, and she cries out in
labour and in torment to give birth.

3 And another sign appeared in heaven, and
look, a great fiery red dragon, with seven heads
and ten horns, and on its heads seven diadems.
4 And its tail sweeps away a third of the stars of
heaven, and it threw them to the earth. And the
dragon stood before the woman who was about
to give birth, so that when she gave birth it
might devour her child. 5 And she gave birth to
a son, a male child, who is to shepherd all the
nations with an iron rod. And her child was
snatched up to God and to his throne. 6 And the
woman fled into the wilderness, where she has
a place prepared by God, so that there she
might be fed for a thousand two hundred and
sixty days.

7 And war broke out in heaven: Michael and his
angels made war against the dragon. And the
dragon made war, and its angels, 8 but it was not
strong enough, and no place was found for
them in heaven any longer. 9 And the great
dragon was thrown down, the ancient serpent,
who is called the devil and Satan, who deceives
the whole world – he was thrown down to the
earth, and his angels were thrown down with
him.

10 And I heard a loud voice in heaven saying:

Now have come the salvation and the power
and the kingdom of our God
and the authority of his Christ,
for the accuser of our brothers and sisters has
been thrown down,
who accuses them before our God day and
night.
11 And they have conquered him by the blood of
the Lamb
and by the word of their testimony,
and they did not love their life even to death.
12 Therefore rejoice, you heavens,
and you whose tent is in them!
Woe to the earth and the sea,
for the devil has come down to you
with great fury,
because he knows that he has only a little time.

13 And when the dragon saw that it had been
thrown down to the earth, it pursued the
woman who had given birth to the male child.
14 And the two wings of the great eagle were
given to the woman, so that she might fly into
the wilderness to her place, where she is fed for
a time and times and half a time, away from the
face of the serpent. 15 And the serpent spewed
water like a river out of its mouth after the
woman, so that the river would sweep her
away. 16 And the earth helped the woman, and
the earth opened its mouth and swallowed the
river that the dragon had spewed out of its
mouth. 17 And the dragon was angry with the
woman and went off to make war against the
rest of her offspring, those who keep the com-
mandments of God and hold to the testimony of
Jesus. 18 And it took its stand on the sand of the
sea.

1 And I saw a beast coming up out of the sea,
with ten horns and seven heads, and on its
horns ten diadems, and on its heads names of
blasphemy. 2 And the beast that I saw was like a
leopard, and its feet were like a bear's, and its
mouth like a lion's mouth. And the dragon gave
it its power and its throne and great authority.
3 And one of its heads seemed slaughtered to
death, and its death wound was healed. And the
whole earth followed the beast in amazement,
4 and they worshipped the dragon, because it
had given the authority to the beast, and they
worshipped the beast, saying, "Who is like the
beast, and who can make war against it?"

[5] And it was given a mouth speaking great
things and blasphemies, and it was given au-
thority to act for forty-two months. [6] And it
opened its mouth in blasphemies against God,
to blaspheme his name and his tent – those
whose tent is in heaven. [7] And it was allowed to
make war against the saints and to conquer
them, and it was given authority over every
tribe and people and language and nation. [8] And
all who live on the earth will worship it – every-
one whose name has not been written in the
book of life of the slaughtered Lamb from the
foundation of the world.

[9] If anyone has an ear, he should hear. [10] If any-
one is for captivity, into captivity he goes; if
anyone is to be killed with the sword, with the
sword he will be killed. Here is the endurance
and the faith of the saints.

[11] And I saw another beast coming up out of the
earth, and it had two horns like a lamb, and it
spoke like a dragon. [12] And it exercises all the
authority of the first beast in its presence, and it
makes the earth and those who live on it wor-
ship the first beast, whose death wound was
healed. [13] And it performs great signs, so that it
even makes fire come down from heaven to the
earth before people. [14] And it deceives those
who live on the earth by the signs that it was al-
lowed to perform in the presence of the beast,
telling those who live on the earth to make an
image for the beast that has the wound of the
sword and came to life. [15] And it was allowed to
give breath to the image of the beast, so that the
image of the beast would even speak and would
cause all who do not worship the image of the
beast to be killed. [16] And it makes everyone, the
small and the great, the rich and the poor, the
free and the slaves, to be given a mark on their
right hand or on their forehead, [17] so that no
one can buy or sell unless he has the mark: the
name of the beast or the number of its name.
[18] Here is wisdom: whoever has understanding
should calculate the number of the beast, for it
is the number of a human being. And its num-
ber is six hundred and sixty-six.

SESSION 9 · REVELATION 14:1 – 16:21

The Song on the Shore

THE BIG IDEA

After the dragon and the beasts, the curtain opens on the Lamb standing on Zion with his people, who bear his name and sing the song of Moses and of the Lamb before a single bowl is poured out – God's judgement on evil is real and just, but those who belong to the Lamb are kept, and the end of evil has already been decided.

TO GET STARTED

Is there a song that carries you through hard times – one you sing or hum when things are difficult? What does it do for you?

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 14:1 – 16:21

Three readers, one per chapter. In 14:6–11 let three voices take the three angels; the whole group reads the song of 15:3–4 together; in chapter 16 the reader pauses briefly after each bowl, and the group reads the answer of the altar (16:7) aloud.

TIMING

5 min	Welcome & opener
15 min	Read the passage
10 min	Background & original language
40 min	Discussion
15 min	Application & prayer

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

In chapter 13 the dragon and his two beasts seemed to rule the world, and no one could buy or sell without the beast's mark. Chapters 14–16 draw back the curtain again: the Lamb stands on Mount Zion with the whole people of God, angels proclaim an eternal gospel and the harvest of the earth is gathered in. Then come the seven last plagues: before a single bowl is poured out, the conquerors sing on the shore of the sea of glass, and then the bowls fall like the plagues of Egypt on the kingdom of the beast – until the voice from the throne cries, "It is done!"

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

- ***gegrammenon epi tōn metōpōn autōn* – γεγραμμένον ἐπὶ τῶν μετώπων αὐτῶν** "written on their foreheads": The verb form describes something that has been written and stays written. The mark of the beast has to be enforced (13:16); the name of the Lamb and of his Father is a lasting gift (14:1; cf. 7:3; 22:4). No one is unmarked – everyone belongs to someone.
- ***tēn ōdēn Mōyseōs … kai tēn ōdēn tou arniou* – τὴν ᾠδὴν Μωϋσέως … καὶ τὴν ᾠδὴν τοῦ ἀρνίου** "the song of Moses … and the song of the Lamb": Probably not two songs but one: the song of the exodus (Exodus 15), now sung about a greater exodus. The blood of the Passover lamb brought Israel out of Egypt; the blood of the Lamb has purchased people for God from every nation (5:9).
- ***Gegonen* – Γέγονεν** "It is done!": The perfect tense: something has happened and stands. The kings are still gathering for war, yet the outcome is already decided. The same word sounds again at the new creation (21:6).

DISCUSSION

1. After the beast's mark: "And I looked, and there was the Lamb, standing on Mount Zion". The dragon stood on the sand of the sea (12:18); the Lamb stands on the rock of Zion. What would this have meant to a believer in Pergamum who felt almost alone in not bowing down? Where do you need this look behind the curtain today? (Revelation 14:1)

2. The 144,000 have “his name and his Father's name written on their foreheads” and follow the Lamb wherever he goes. Which label (job, income, looks, failures) weighs on you most, and what changes when his name is written over it? Where are you reluctant to follow the Lamb at the moment? (Revelation 14:1–5)
3. Before the fall of Babylon and the solemn warning, an angel flies with “an eternal gospel” for every nation: “Fear God and give him glory”. Why do you think the gospel comes first? And what does verse 13 say to someone who has lost a loved one in the Lord? (Revelation 14:6–13)
4. The conquerors stand beside the sea of glass and sing “the song of Moses, the servant of God, and the song of the Lamb”. Read Exodus 15:1–2, 11 and Jeremiah 10:6–7 aloud. What links do you see between Israel on the shore of the Red Sea and God's people here? What is the greater exodus the Lamb has brought about? (Revelation 15:2–4)
5. The song comes before the bowls, and there is not a word in it about the singers' own suffering or courage – every line is about God. Where are you standing at the moment: still in the sea, or already on the shore? What would it mean to sing “just and true are your ways” there already? (Revelation 15:3–4)
6. The bowls bring back the plagues of Egypt (Exodus 7–10). Twice we read that “they did not repent”, and three times that they blasphemed God. What does Pharaoh's story teach about why judgement alone does not change a heart? When something hurts, do you become softer or harder towards God? (Revelation 16:1–11)
7. The altar says: “Yes, Lord God, the Almighty, true and just are your judgements.” And Christ says: “Look, I am coming like a thief. Blessed is the one who stays awake and keeps his clothes”. How do these voices comfort those who suffer injustice? What does “staying awake” mean for you – without calculating dates? (Revelation 16:5–17)

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- Tonight write on a card: I belong to the Lamb. Put it by the mirror, and each morning read 15:3–4 aloud and thank God for one concrete work he has done in your life.
- Take two minutes one evening to ask where you have fallen asleep this week – in prayer, honesty or love. Then pray for one person or place that suffers injustice, using the words of 16:7.

PRAY TOGETHER

Begin by reading 15:3–4 aloud together, or sing a song of praise the group knows. Then pray in twos or threes: thank the Lamb that his name is written over your life, name one situation in which you feel you are still in the sea, and pray for one place in the world that suffers injustice. Close together with 16:7: “Yes, Lord God, the Almighty, true and just are your judgements.”

NOTES FOR THE LEADER

- This session covers three chapters and three devotionals (days 20–22). Chapter 16 is hard; do not skip it, but protect time for questions 4 and 5 – the song on the shore is the heart of the evening.
- The 144,000 (14:1–5) are, as in 7:4–9, the whole people of God, not an elite group or a single nation. “Virgins” (14:4) is the Old Testament picture of soldiers keeping themselves pure for holy war (Deuteronomy 23:9–14; 1 Samuel 21:5) and of Israel following her God faithfully (Jeremiah 2:2) – it does not mean that only the unmarried belong to the Lamb.
- The bowls are not the next chapter in a calendar but the same reality as the trumpets (8–9), now in full seriousness: God's patience with evil has an end. Some group members may read them as a future period just before Christ's return (futurist), others only as Rome's judgement (preterist); name these views fairly in a sentence and come back to the pastoral message. Armageddon (16:16) is most likely “the mountain of Megiddo”, a symbol of the final revolt – the battle itself is never described. Steer away from maps and news headlines.
- Handle the language of wrath with care (14:10–11, 19–20; 16). Some people grew up with preaching that made them afraid. Stress what the devotionals stress: this is comfort for those who suffer, not a weapon to threaten others; God's wrath is his faithfulness to the victims; those sealed by God do not stand under it (7:3; Exodus 8:22). Read the chapter about our own hearts, not about other people.
- The new exodus runs through these chapters – the seal on the forehead, the song by the sea, the tent of witness (15:5; Exodus 40:34–35), the plagues. Let the group discover it in question 4 rather than explaining it in advance.
- Point ahead: next week chapters 17–19 – the prostitute on the beast, the fall of Babylon, the wedding of the Lamb and the Rider called Faithful and True.

Related devotionals: Day 20 – The Lamb on Mount Zion: His Name on Our Foreheads · Day 21 – The Song of Moses and of the Lamb: Singing on the Shore · Day 22 – The Seven Bowls Are Poured Out: It Is Done!

Revelation 14:1 – 16:21

1 And I looked, and there was the Lamb, standing on Mount Zion, and with him a hundred and forty-four thousand who had his name and his Father's name written on their foreheads.
2 And I heard a sound from heaven like the sound of many waters and like the sound of loud thunder; and the sound that I heard was like lyre players playing on their lyres. 3 And they sing something like a new song before the throne and before the four living creatures and the elders; and no one could learn the song except the hundred and forty-four thousand, who have been purchased from the earth. 4 These are the ones who have not defiled themselves with women, for they are virgins. These are the ones who follow the Lamb wherever he goes. These were purchased from among people as firstfruits for God and for the Lamb, 5 and no lie was found in their mouth; they are without blemish.

6 And I saw another angel flying in midheaven, with an eternal gospel to proclaim to those who are settled on the earth and to every nation and tribe and language and people. 7 He said with a loud voice, "Fear God and give him glory, for the hour of his judgement has come; and worship the one who made heaven and earth and sea and the springs of water!"

8 And another, a second angel, followed, saying, "Fallen, fallen is Babylon the Great, who has made all the nations drink of the wine of the fury of her harlotry!"

9 And another, a third angel, followed them, saying with a loud voice, "If anyone worships the beast and its image and receives a mark on his forehead or on his hand, 10 he too will drink of the wine of the fury of God, poured undiluted into the cup of his wrath, and he will be tormented with fire and sulphur before holy angels and before the Lamb. 11 And the smoke of their torment goes up for ever and ever, and they have no rest day or night, those who worship the beast and its image, and whoever receives the mark of its name." 12 Here is the endurance of the saints, those who keep the commandments of God and faith in Jesus.

13 And I heard a voice from heaven saying, "Write: Blessed are the dead who die in the Lord from now on." "Yes," says the Spirit, "so that they may rest from their toil, for their works go with them."

14 And I looked, and there was a white cloud, and seated on the cloud was one like a son of man, with a golden crown on his head and a sharp sickle in his hand. 15 And another angel came out of the temple, crying out with a loud voice to the one seated on the cloud, "Send out your sickle and reap, for the hour to reap has come, for the harvest of the earth is dry and ripe." 16 And the one seated on the cloud swung his sickle over the earth, and the earth was reaped.

17 And another angel came out of the temple in heaven, and he too had a sharp sickle. 18 And another angel came from the altar, the one who has authority over the fire, and he called with a loud voice to the one who had the sharp sickle, saying, "Send out your sharp sickle and gather the clusters from the vine of the earth, for its grapes are ripe." 19 And the angel swung his sickle over the earth and gathered the vintage of the vine of the earth and threw it into the great winepress of the fury of God. 20 And the winepress was trodden outside the city, and blood came out of the winepress up to the horses' bridles, for a distance of a thousand six hundred stadia.

1 And I saw another sign in heaven, great and wonderful: seven angels with seven plagues, the last ones, for with them the fury of God is completed.

2 And I saw something like a sea of glass mixed
with fire, and those who conquer the beast and
its image and the number of its name, standing
beside the sea of glass, holding lyres of God.
3 And they sing the song of Moses, the servant
of God, and the song of the Lamb, saying:

Great and wonderful are your works,
Lord God, the Almighty;
just and true are your ways,
King of the ages.
4 Who will not fear you, Lord,
and glorify your name?
For you alone are holy.
For all the nations will come
and worship before you,
for your righteous acts have been revealed.

5 And after this I looked, and the temple of the
tent of witness in heaven was opened, 6 and the
seven angels who had the seven plagues came
out of the temple, dressed in clean, shining
linen, with golden sashes around their chests.
7 And one of the four living creatures gave the
seven angels seven golden bowls full of the fury
of God, who lives for ever and ever. 8 And the
temple was filled with smoke from the glory of
God and from his power, and no one could en-
ter the temple until the seven plagues of the
seven angels were completed.

1 And I heard a loud voice from the temple say-
ing to the seven angels, "Go and pour out the
seven bowls of the fury of God on the earth!"

2 And the first went and poured out his bowl on
the earth; and a foul and evil sore came on the
people who had the mark of the beast and who
worshipped its image.

3 And the second poured out his bowl into the
sea; and it became blood like that of a dead
man, and every living soul died, everything
that was in the sea.

4 And the third poured out his bowl into the
rivers and the springs of water; and they be-
came blood. 5 And I heard the angel of the wa-
ters say:

Just are you, who is and who was, the Holy
One,
because you have judged these things;
6 for they poured out the blood of saints and
prophets,
and you have given them blood to drink.
They deserve it.

7 And I heard the altar say:

Yes, Lord God, the Almighty,
true and just are your judgements.

8 And the fourth poured out his bowl on the
sun; and it was allowed to scorch people with
fire. 9 And the people were scorched with fierce
heat, and they blasphemed the name of God,
who has authority over these plagues, and they
did not repent and give him glory.

10 And the fifth poured out his bowl on the
throne of the beast; and its kingdom was
plunged into darkness, and people gnawed
their tongues in pain, 11 and they blasphemed
the God of heaven because of their pains and
their sores, and they did not repent of their
works.

12 And the sixth poured out his bowl on the
great river, the Euphrates; and its water was
dried up, so that the way would be prepared for
the kings from the rising of the sun. 13 And I
saw coming out of the mouth of the dragon and
out of the mouth of the beast and out of the
mouth of the false prophet three unclean spir-
its like frogs. 14 For they are spirits of demons
that perform signs, and they go out to the kings
of the whole world, to gather them for the war
of the great day of God, the Almighty. 15 – "Look,
I am coming like a thief. Blessed is the one who
stays awake and keeps his clothes, so that he
does not walk around naked and people see his
shame." – 16 And they gathered them at the place
that is called in Hebrew Armageddon.

17 And the seventh poured out his bowl into the
air; and a loud voice came out of the temple,
from the throne, saying, "It is done!" 18 And
there were lightning and sounds and thunder,

and there was a great earthquake, such as there had never been since people were on the earth, so great an earthquake, so mighty. [19] And the great city split into three parts, and the cities of the nations fell. And God remembered Babylon the Great, to give her the cup of the wine of the fury of his wrath. [20] And every island fled, and mountains were not found. [21] And great hail, each stone as heavy as a talent, comes down from heaven on the people; and the people blasphemed God because of the plague of the hail, for its plague is exceedingly great.